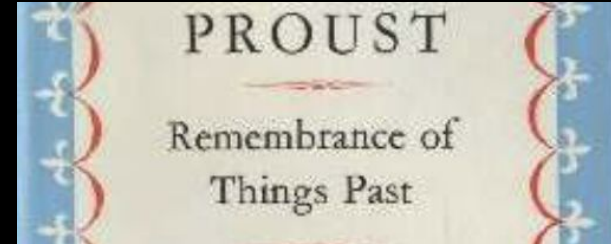


Overview of the CMB Field

Suzanne Staggs
Princeton University
15 July 2026

2026 Flatiron Institute CMB Summer School



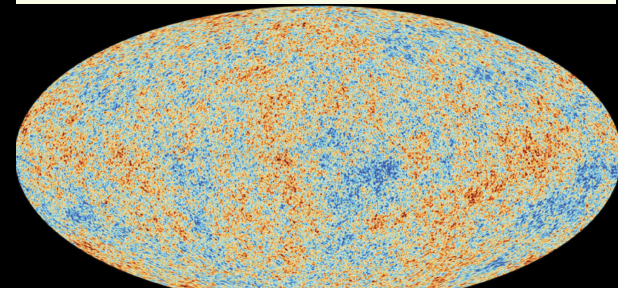
THE PRIMEVAL FIREBALL

Volume Three

The earth is bathed in radio waves that appear to have originated at the time of the primordial "big bang." This radiation provides the cosmologist with a rare new clue to the nature of the universe

by P. J. E. Peebles and David T. Wilkinson

Scientific American, June 1967



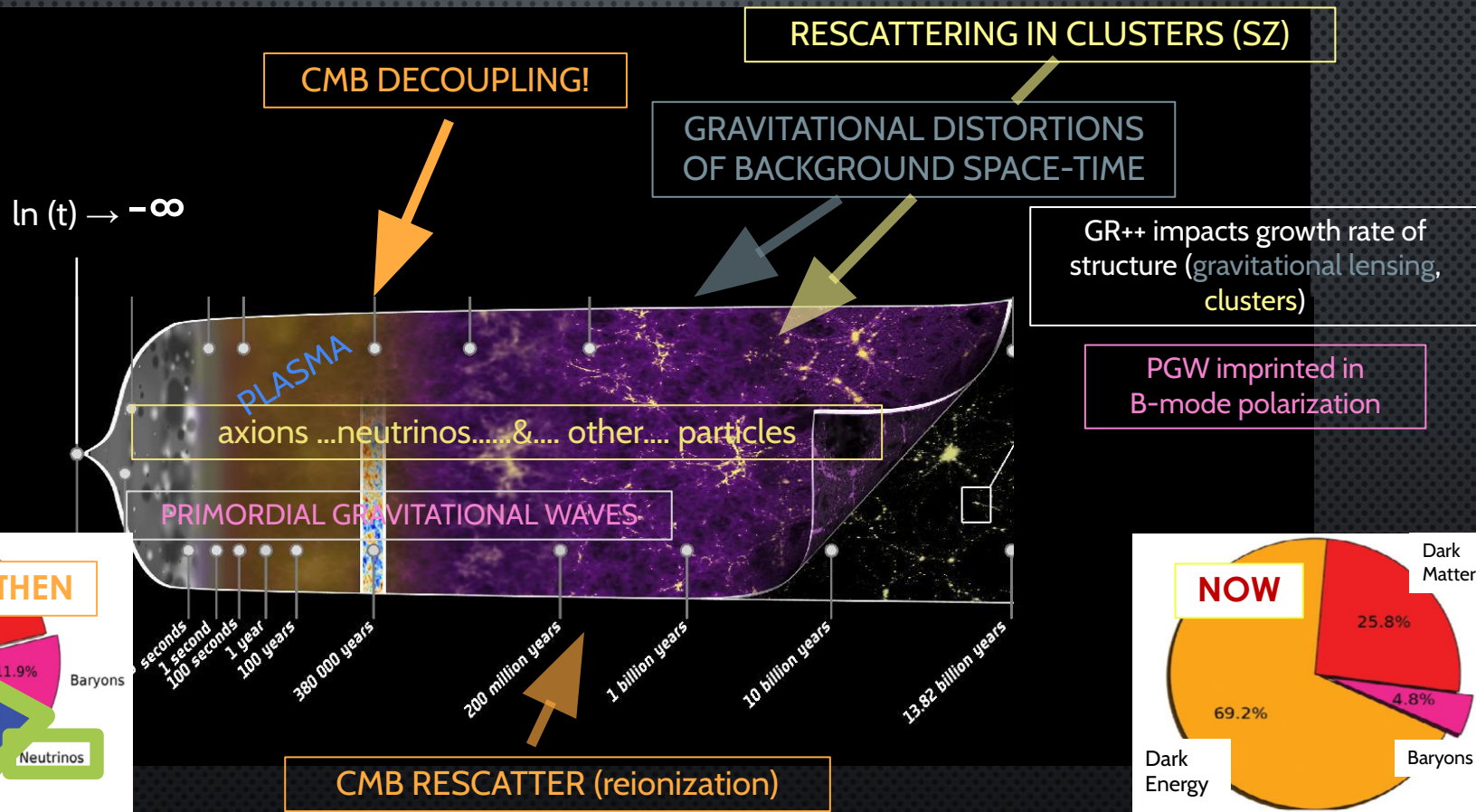
2013: Courtesy Planck Science Team

OUTLINE:

- 1) **CMB as treasure trove / layer cake / archaeological strata**
- 2) Upcoming new CMB data / instruments in brief
- 3) Polarization, Parity, Fourier Space, Real Space, Q, U, E, B
- 4) Deeper dive on CMB instruments

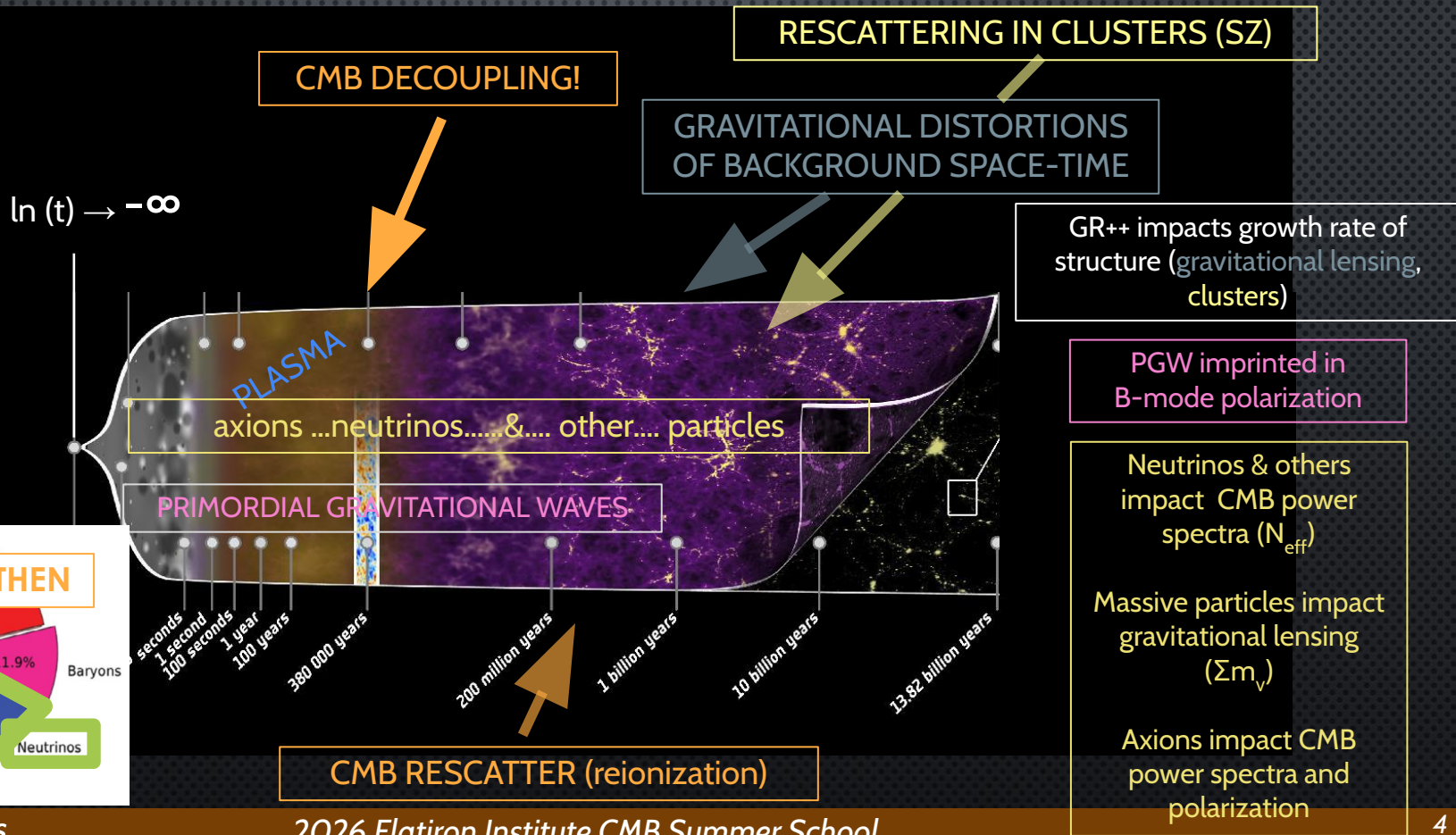
SOURCES OF EVIDENCE IN THE CMB

Base image courtesy of Planck science team



SOURCES OF EVIDENCE IN THE CMB

Base image courtesy of Planck science team



Next Up: Overview of CMB Impact on Cosmology



Overview of CMB Impact on Cosmology

via Screen Shots from Mat Madhavacheril's talk yesterday!

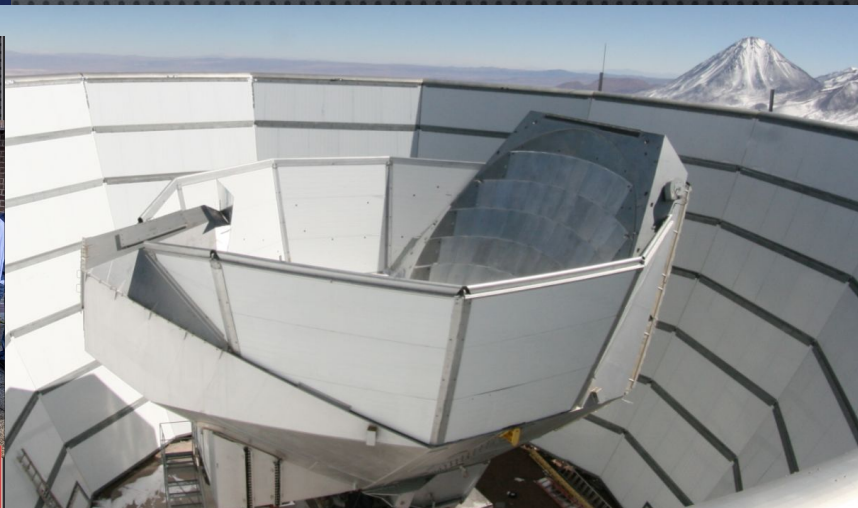
The WMAP+Planck Legacy $\rightarrow$ current generation CMB

- Precision concordance Λ CDM model
- Init. Conditions: Gaussian, adiabatic, slightly red near scale-invariant power
- Dark matter needed to explain acoustic oscillations
- Acceleration due to dark energy (indep. evidence from CMB)
- Three relativistic/light neutrinos, $N_{\text{eff}} \sim 3$
- Explore space of models for H_0 tension
- New light particles ΔN_{eff}
- Dark matter interactions
- Inflationary gravitational waves, r with B-modes
- Reconstructions and cross-correlations of mass (lensing), gas pressure (tSZ), velocities and gas density (kSZ)
 - Measure neutrino mass Σm_ν
 - Precision tests of non-Gaussianity from multi-field inflation f_{NL}
 - Measure baryonic feedback, constrain galaxy formation

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Staggs Bona Fides & Biases (1)



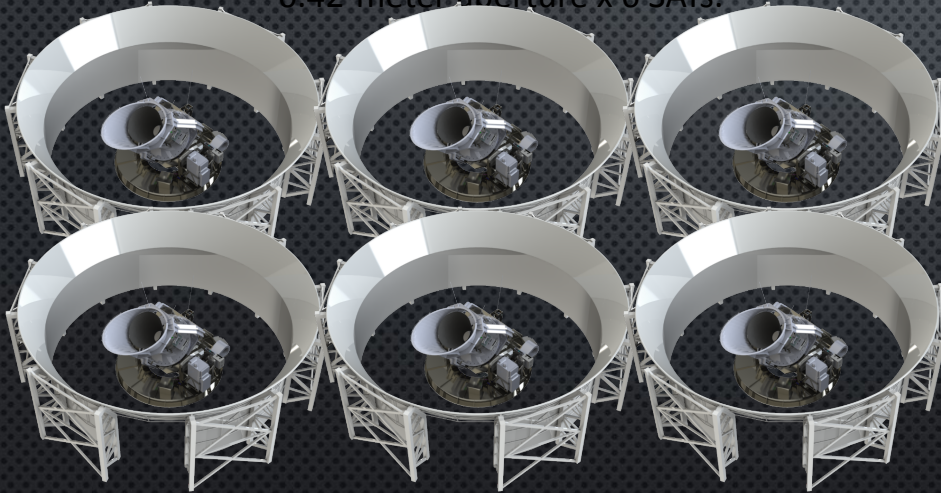
ATACAMA COSMOLOGY TELESCOPE 2007–2022

6 m off-axis telescope (arcminute resolution) formerly @ 5200 m (high) in a desert (dry) at latitude -23° (north-ish)

Staggs Bona Fides & Biases (2)

Small Aperture Telescopes (SATs)

- 0.42-meter aperture x 6 SATs.



Large Aperture Telescope (LAT)

- 6-meter aperture (huge focal plane)



SIMONS OBSERVATORY

@ 5200 m (high) in a desert (dry) at latitude -23° (north-ish)



Staggs Bona Fides & Biases (2)



> 450 collaboration members (300 with PhDs)



SIMONS OBSERVATORY

@ 5200 m (high) in a desert (dry) at latitude -23° (north-ish)

TAXONOMY OF UPCOMING CMB DATA

High resolution maps

- Arcminute resolution
- Deep and wide
- Multiple frequencies spanning 20-300 GHz
- Temperature & (linear) polarization
- High cadence time resolution capabilities



Fodder for myriad studies

Polarization data

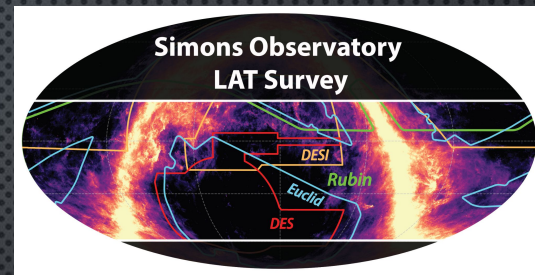
- Very deep maps
- Degree scale resolution
- High fidelity recovery of low ℓ s
- Multiple frequencies spanning 20-300 GHz



PAROCHIAL EXAMPLE OF SO PLANNED SURVEYS

High resolution maps

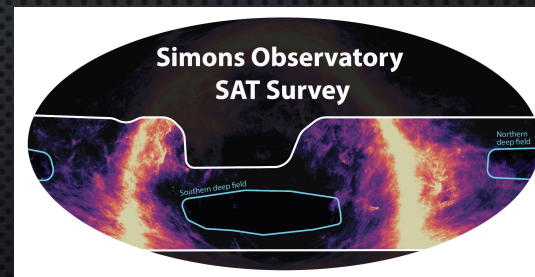
- Arcminute resolution
- Deep and wide
- Multiple frequencies spanning 20-300 GHz
- Temperature & (linear) polarization
- High cadence time resolution capabilities



and also
SPO (BICEP & SPT-3G+)
ALI-CPT, TAURUS, QUBIC +

Polarization data

- Very deep maps
- Degree scale resolution
- High fidelity recovery of low ℓ s
- Multiple frequencies spanning 20-300 GHz



past.....present.....future

CMB INSTRUMENTS PAST, PRESENT, FUTURE

Street Art in Shoreditch

Artist: **stik**

past.....present.....future

RELIKT-1 (1983-84)

COBE (1989-93)

COBRA (1990)

WMAP (2001-10)

Planck (2009-13)

LiteBIRD (2032+)

others proposed!

SPIDER

SO

ARCADE ARCHEOPS
BOOMERANG EBEX
FIRS MAXIMA MAXIPOL
MSAM PIPER QMAP
QUAD TOPHAT

ABS ACBAR ACME
AMiBA APEX BAM
BEAST BICEP1,2
CAPMAP CBI CG
COMPASS
COSMOSOMAS DASI
KECK ARRAY KUPID
MAT MINT PIQUE
POLAR POLARBEAR
PYTHON QUAD QUIET
QUIJOTE Saskatoon
SZA SuZIE Tenerife VSA

ACT

CLASS

BICEP

SPT

SA

Tenerife

ALI-CPT

TAURUS

QUBIC

OUTLINE:

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STOKES PARAMETERS

Define local x,y system

$$I = \langle E_x^2 + E_y^2 \rangle$$

$$Q = \langle E_x^2 - E_y^2 \rangle$$

$$U = E_x E_y \cos \phi$$

$$V = E_x E_y \sin \phi$$

Q & U are LOCAL; they can be defined at a point on the sky (as can I & V).

STOKES PARAMETERS

VS.

E & B MODES (FLAT SKY)

Define local x,y system

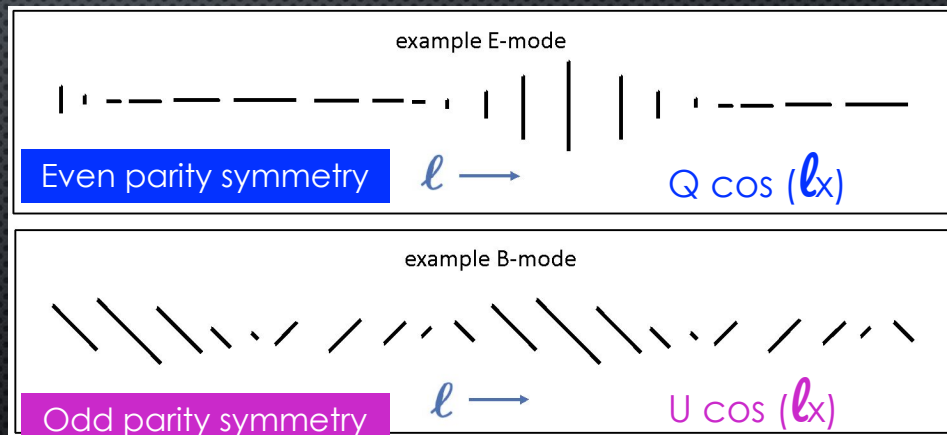
$$I = \langle E_x^2 + E_y^2 \rangle$$

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$$U = E_x E_y \cos \phi$$

$$V = E_x E_y \sin \phi$$

Q & U are LOCAL; they can be defined at a point on the sky (as can I & V).



E & B are GLOBAL rather than local since they are fundamentally defined in the harmonic space.

REAL SPACE, HARMONIC SPACE: ACOUSTIC OSCILLATIONS

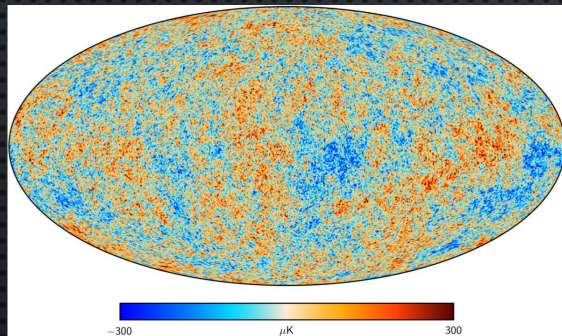
Wiener-Khinchin Theorem

autocorrelation

$$r_{xx}(\tau) = \int_{-\infty}^{\infty} S(f) e^{2\pi i f \tau} df.$$

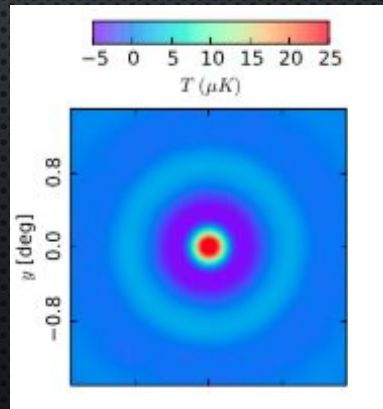
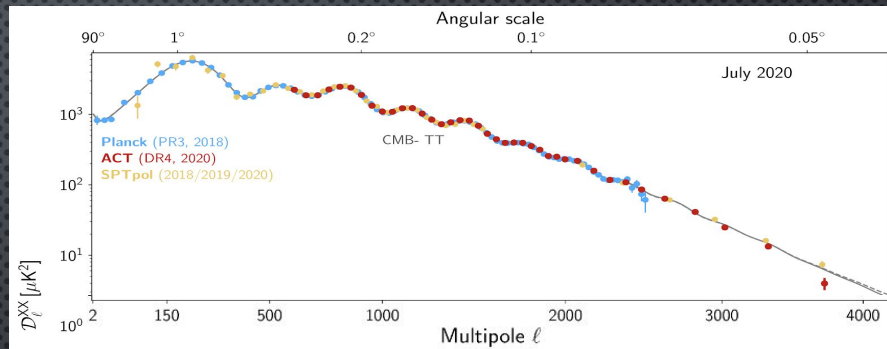
power spectrum

$$S(f) = \int_{-\infty}^{\infty} r_{xx}(\tau) e^{-2\pi i f \tau} d\tau.$$



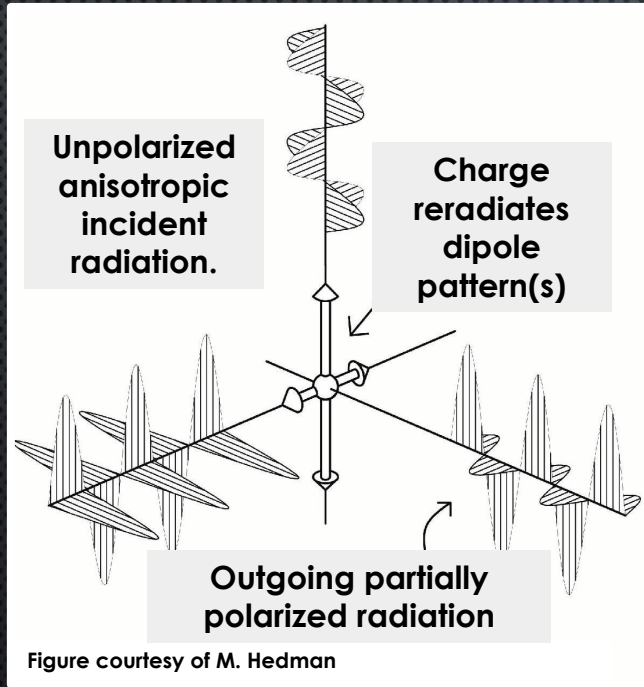
Harmonic
transform

Stack around
hot spots



ACT DR3 IN REAL SPACE
LOUIS ET AL 2016: 1610.02360

CMB POLARIZATION SCHEMATICALLY

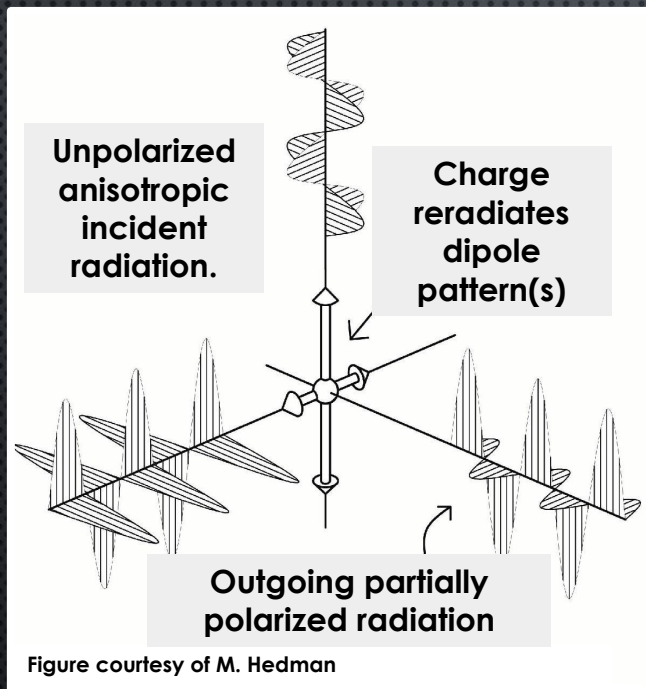


The CMB is slightly polarized by Thomson scattering whenever there is any local quadrupolar anisotropy in the distribution of the scattering electron population.



Acoustic oscillations create local quadrupoles

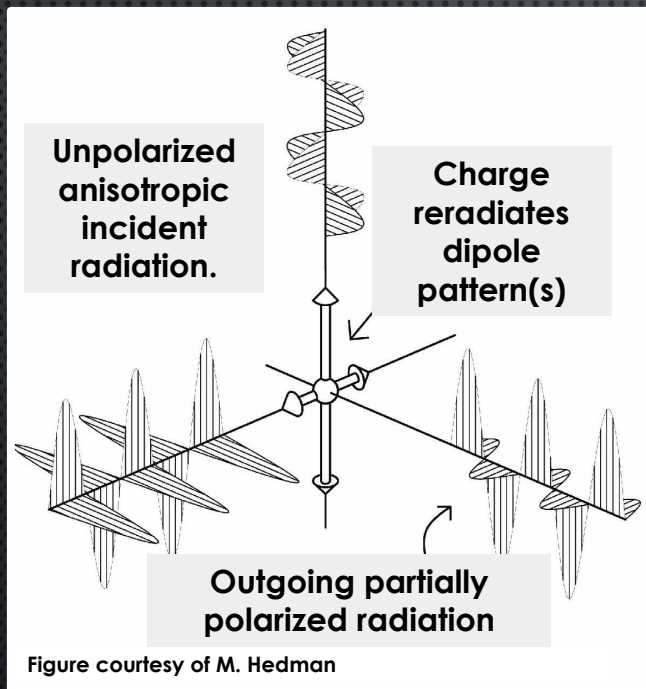
ACOUSTIC OSCILLATIONS & POLARIZATION PATTERNS



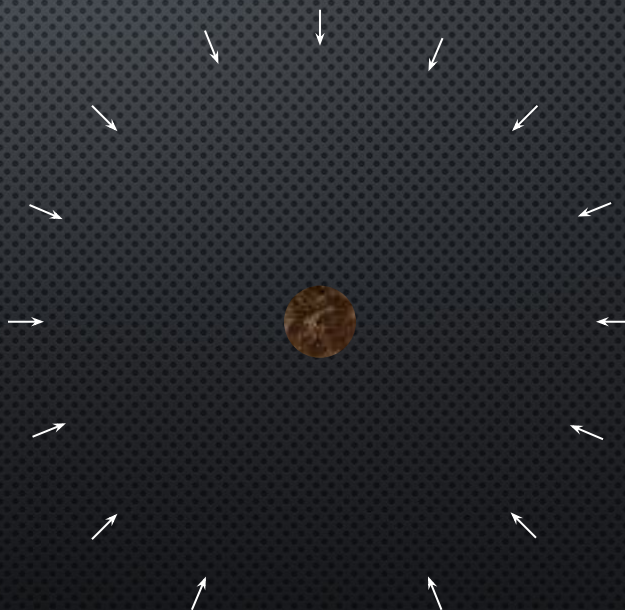
Consider a mass overdensity as plasma begins flowing in



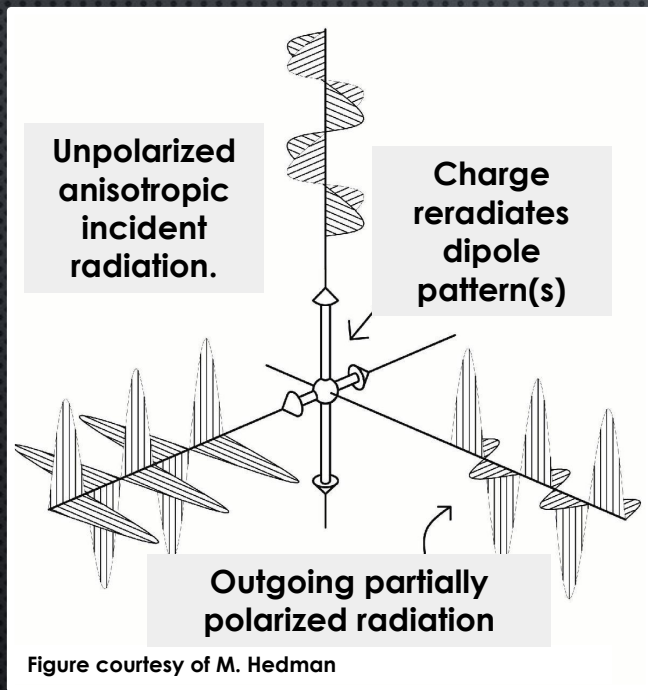
ACOUSTIC OSCILLATIONS & POLARIZATION PATTERNS



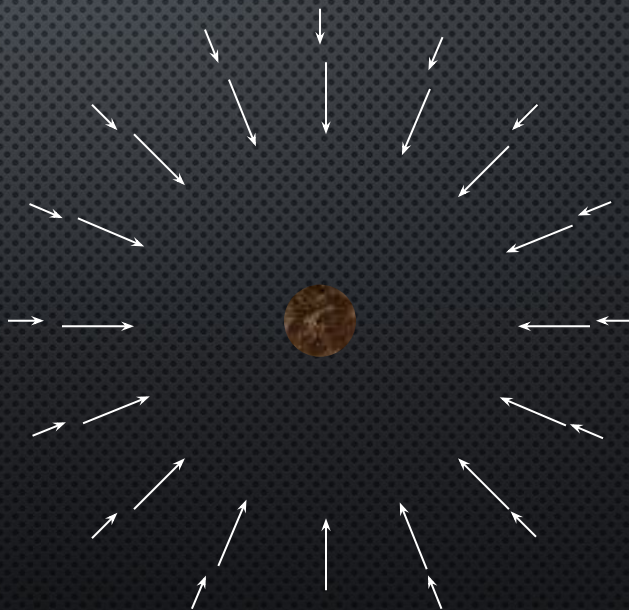
Consider a mass overdensity as plasma begins flowing in



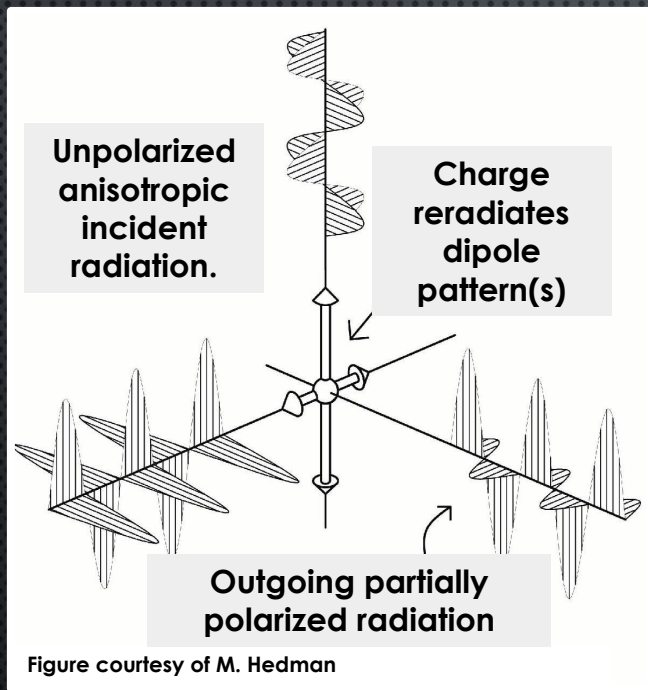
ACOUSTIC OSCILLATIONS & POLARIZATION PATTERNS



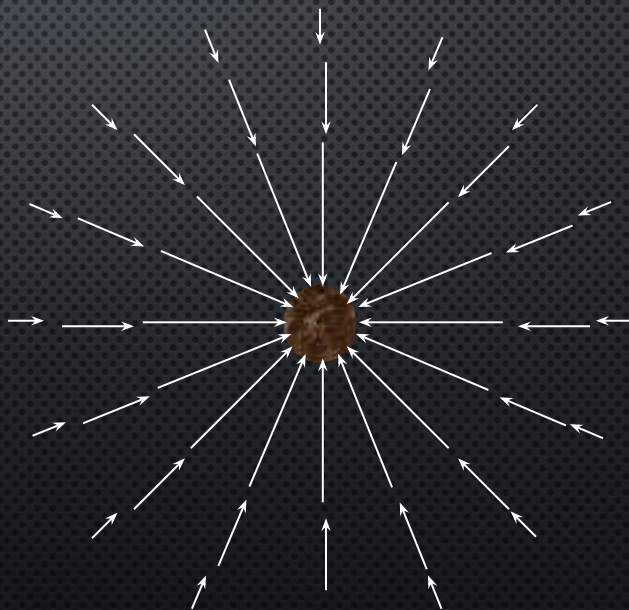
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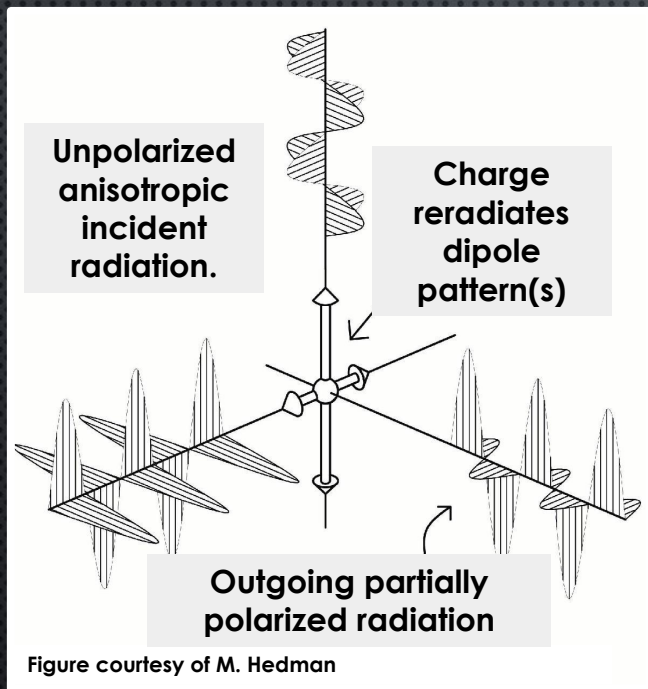
ACOUSTIC OSCILLATIONS & POLARIZATION PATTERNS



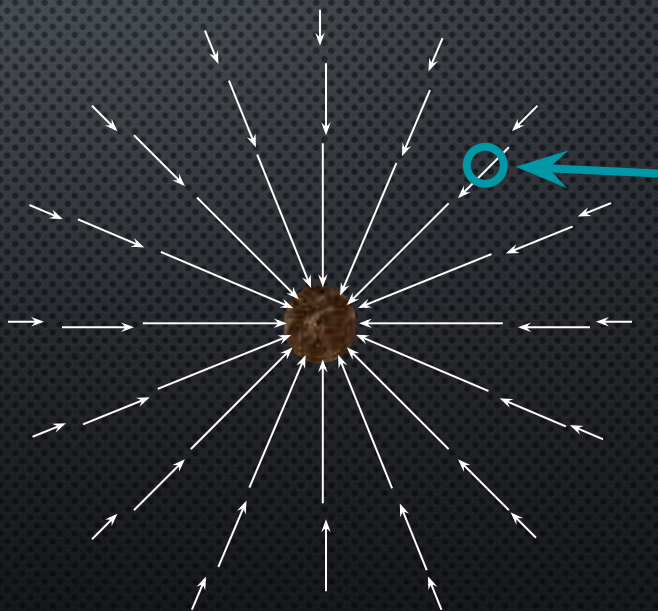
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ACOUSTIC OSCILLATIONS & POLARIZATION PATTERNS

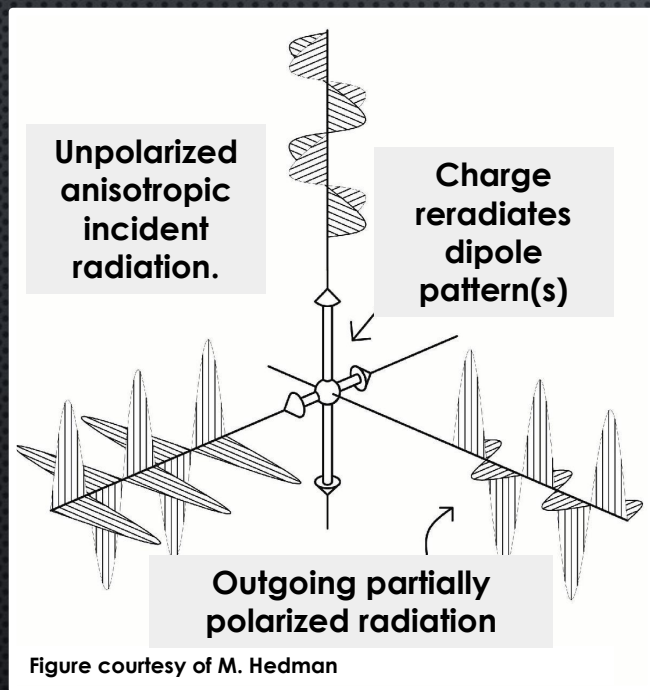


Consider a mass overdensity as plasma begins flowing in

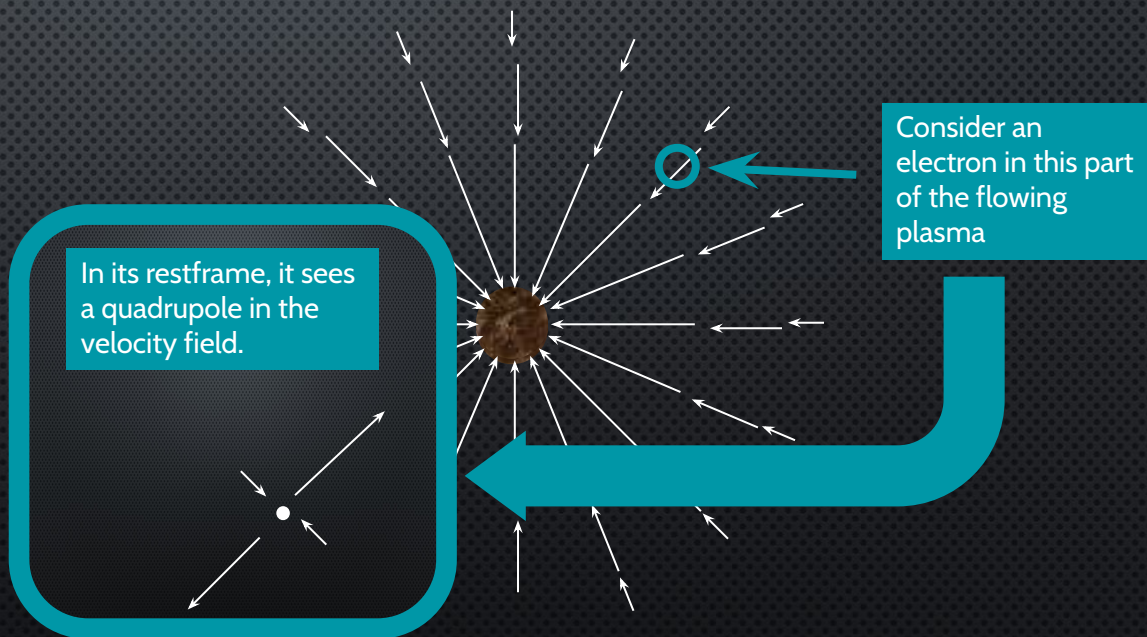


Consider an electron in this part of the flowing plasma

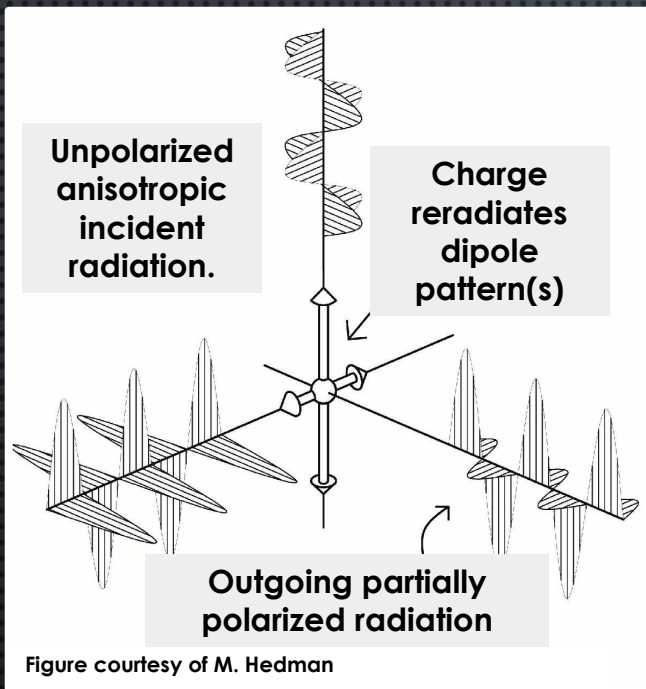
ACOUSTIC OSCILLATIONS & POLARIZATION PATTERNS



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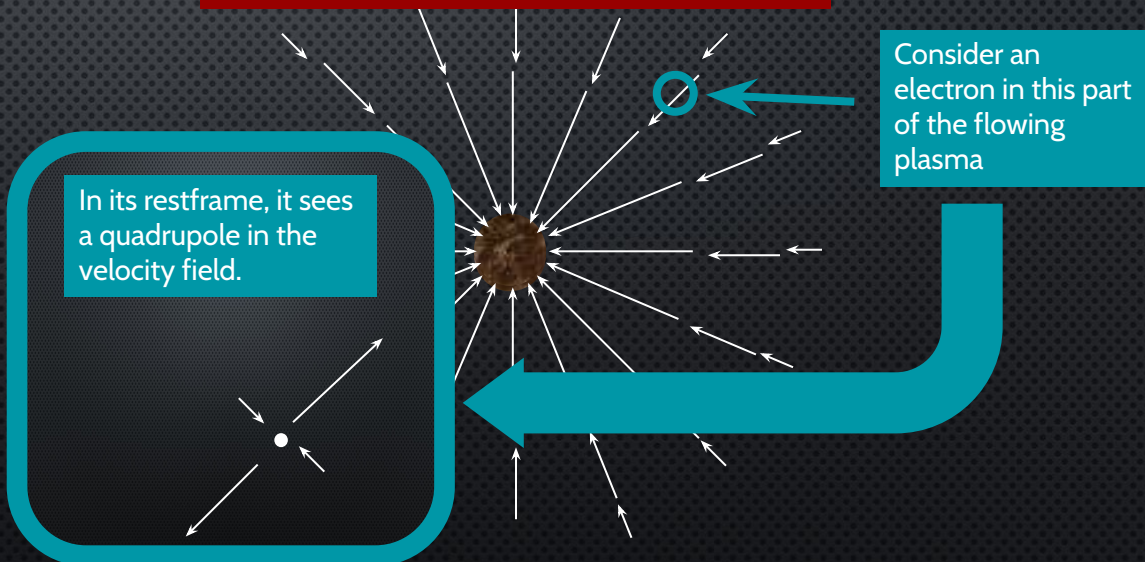
ACOUSTIC OSCILLATIONS & POLARIZATION PATTERNS



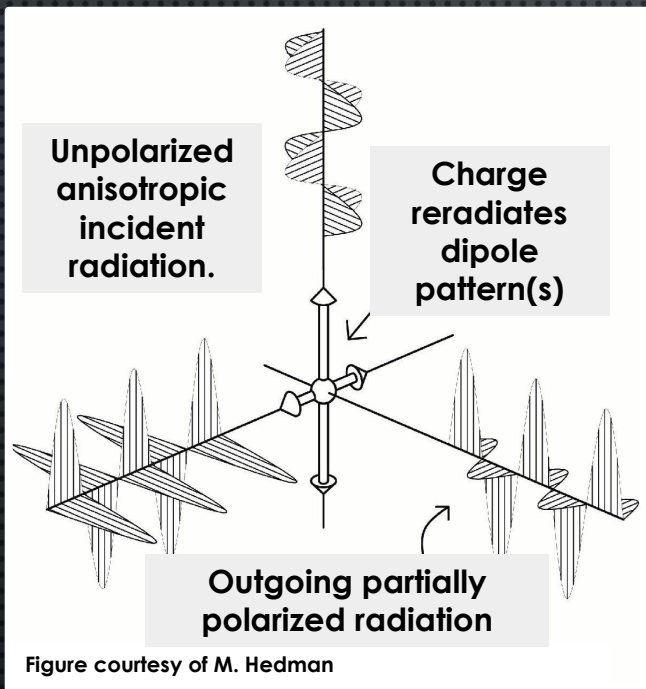
Acoustic oscillations create local quadrupoles (Doppler effect)

Consider a mass overdensity as plasma begins flowing in

Doppler shifts provide the requisite intensity quadrupole!



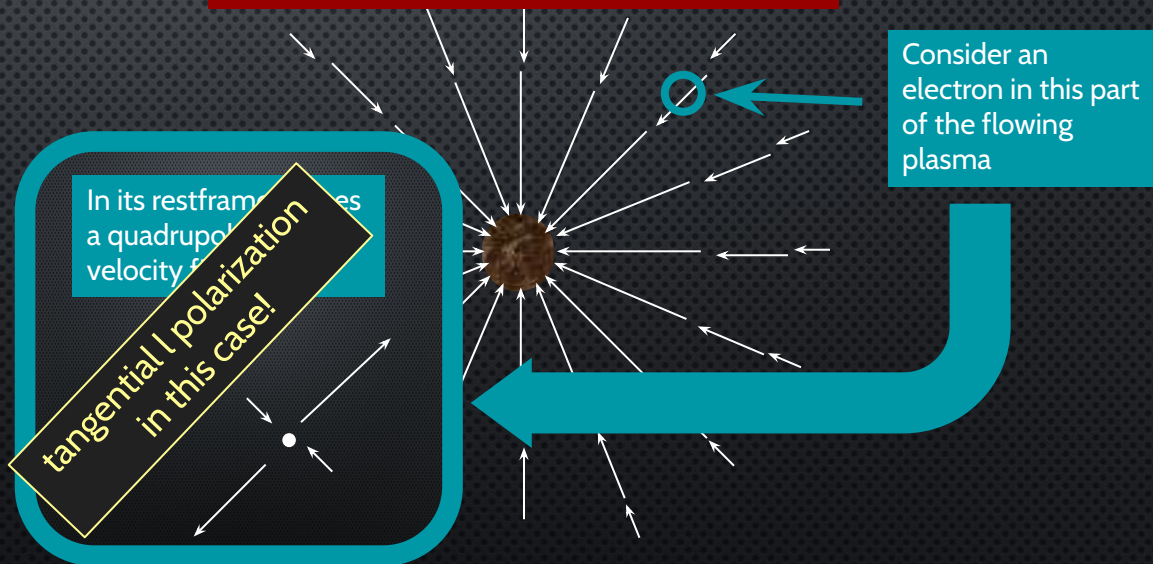
ACOUSTIC OSCILLATIONS & POLARIZATION PATTERNS



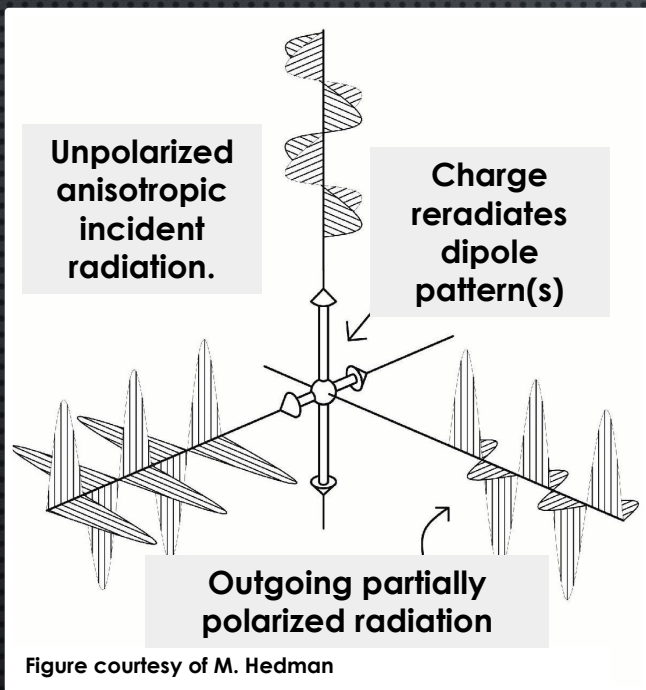
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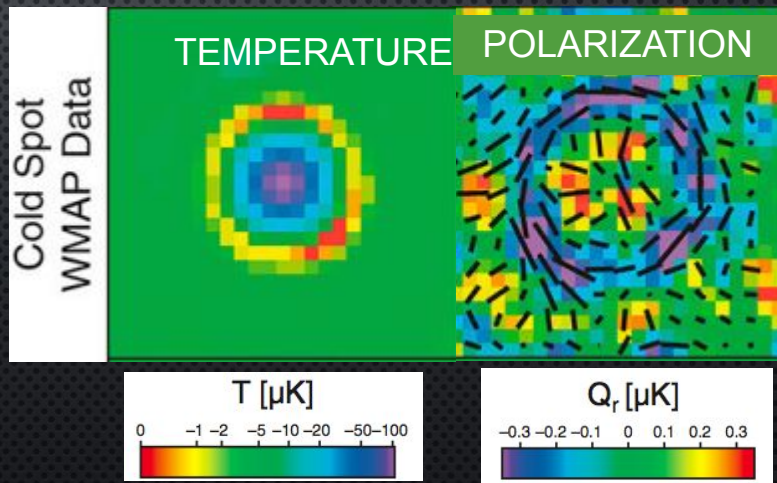


CMB POLARIZATION SCENARIO

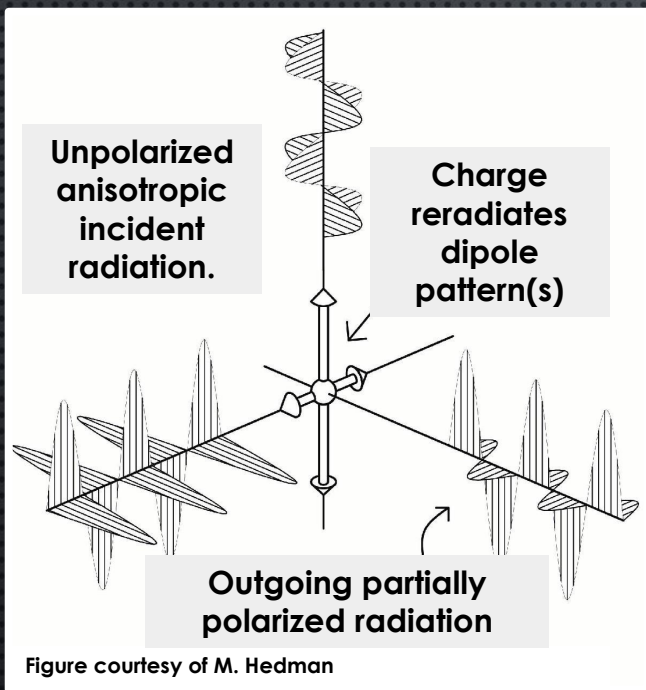


Acoustic oscillations create local quadrupoles (Doppler effect)

WMAP7 stacking on cold spots
Komatsu et al, 2011.

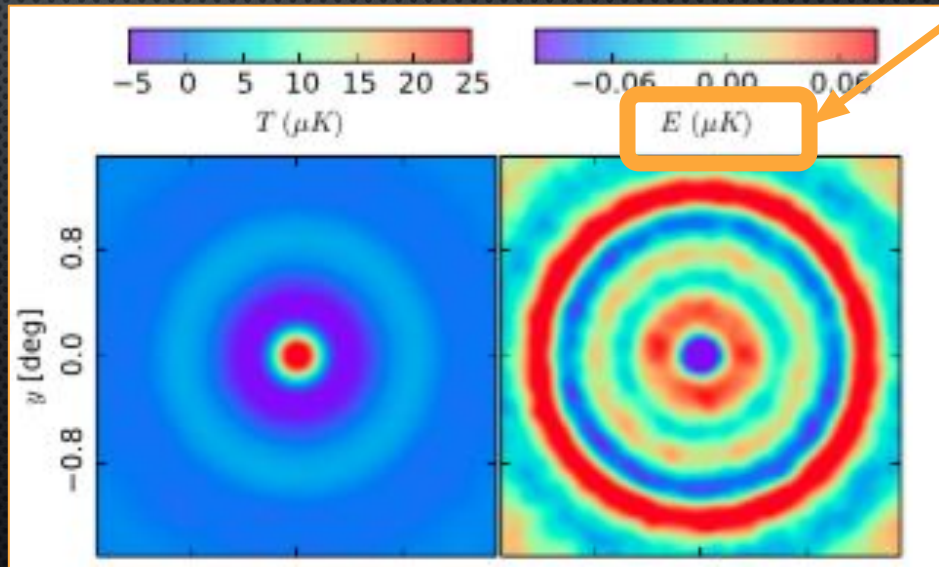


CMB POLARIZATION SCENARIO

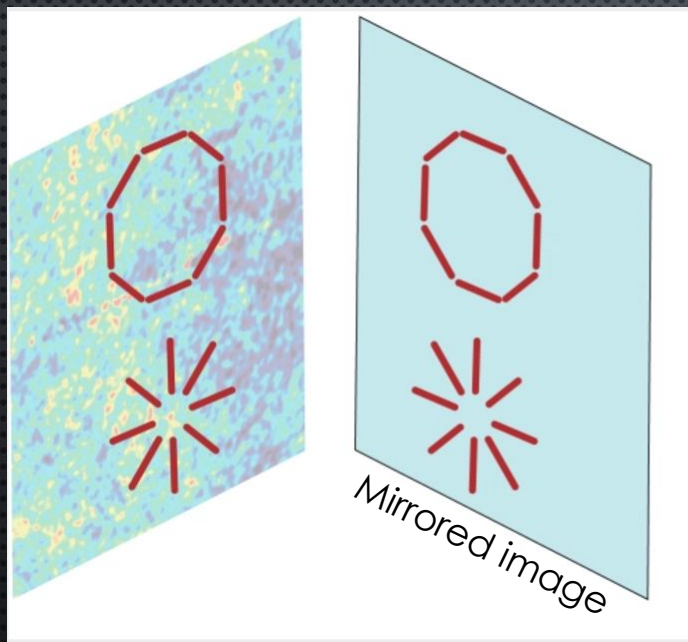


Acoustic oscillations create local quadrupoles (Doppler effect)

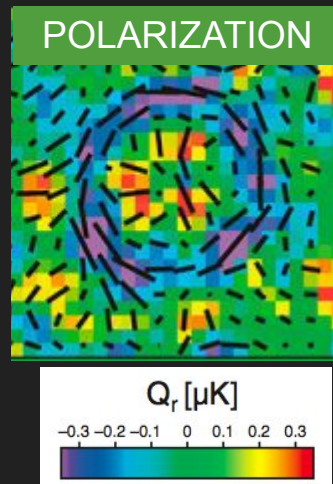
and later:
ACT DR3 IN REAL SPACE
LOUIS ET AL 2016: 1610.02360



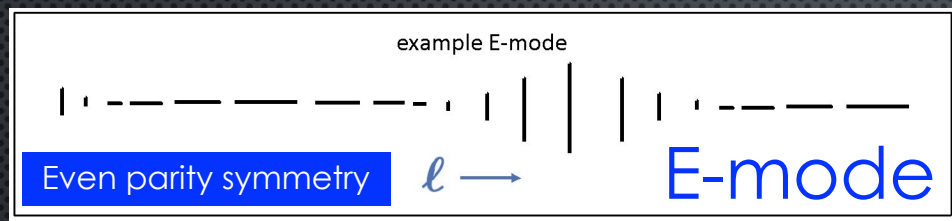
ACOUSTIC OSCILLATIONS PRODUCE E-MODES (WITH EVEN PARITY SYMMETRY)



Radial & tangential polarization
patterns around cold/ hot spots



ACOUSTIC OSCILLATIONS PRODUCE E-MODES (WITH EVEN PARITY SYMMETRY)

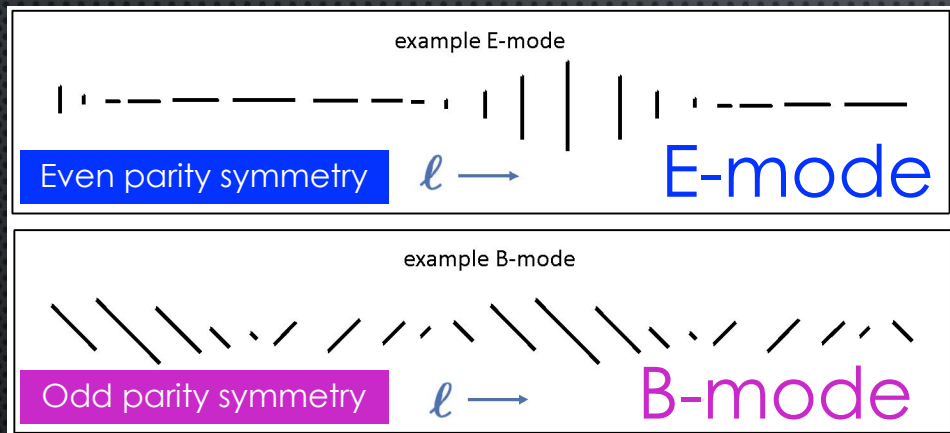


Inflation (or other $P(k)$ progenitor) could cause primordial gravitational waves (PGW).

GRAVITATIONAL WAVES (TENSOR MODES) PRODUCE E **AND** B

ACOUSTIC OSCILLATIONS (SCALAR MODES) PRODUCE ONLY E-MODES!

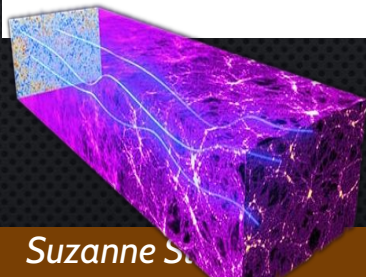
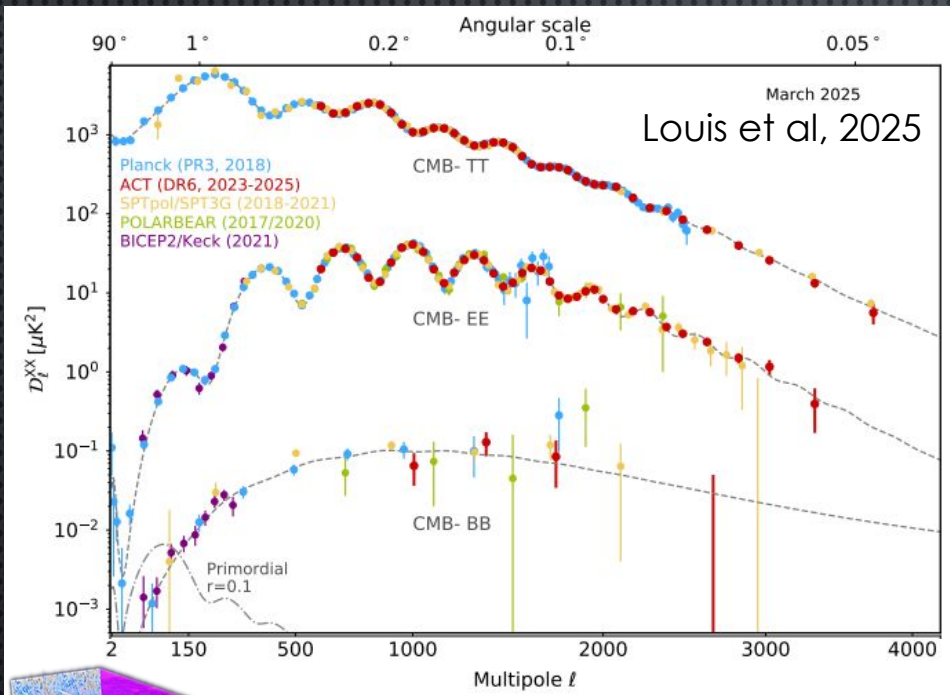
Kamionkowski, Kosowsky & Stebbins; 1997; Seljak & Zaldarriaga 1997



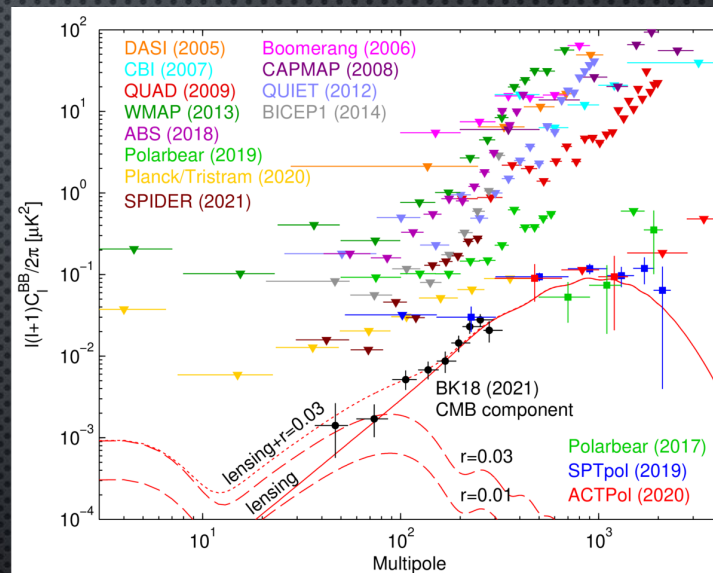
Inflation (or other $P(k)$ progenitor) could cause primordial gravitational waves (PGW).

GRAVITATIONAL WAVES (TENSOR MODES) PRODUCE E **AND** B

MORE ON THE POLARIZATION DATA:



Gravitational lensing
re-arranges spatial patterns,
converting $E \rightarrow B$

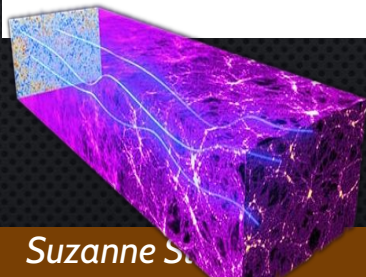
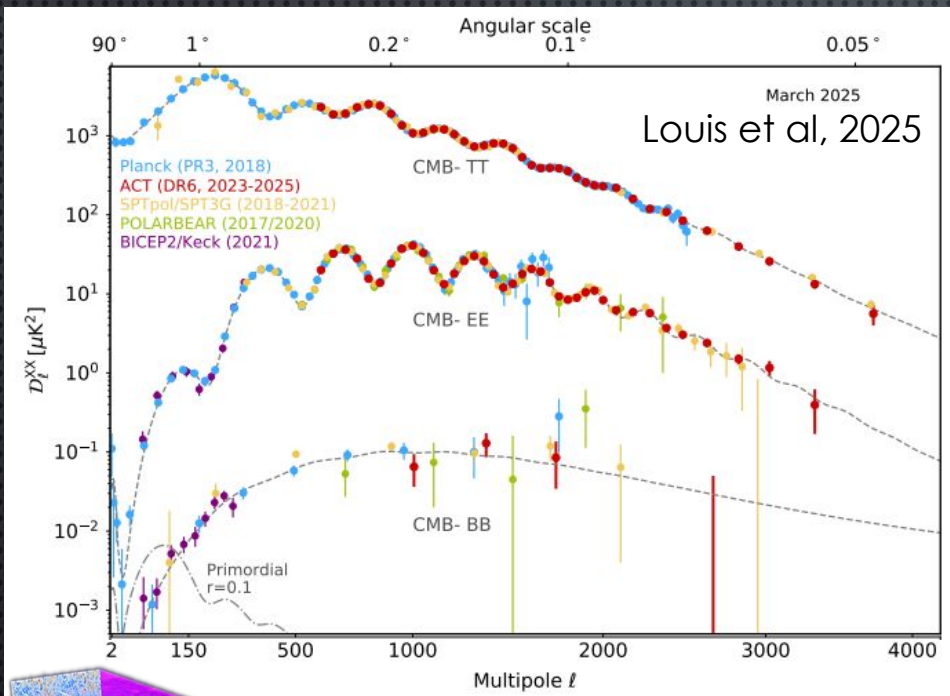


BICEP/Keck Collaboration, PRL 127, 151301, 2021

Current limit on tensor-to-scalar power
spectrum ratio at $k = 0.05 \text{ Mpc}^{-1}$:

$r < 0.036$, 95% CL.

A FEW MORE THINGS ABOUT CMB POLARIZATION DATA:



Gravitational lensing arises from dozens of arcminute deflections of geodesics

- Primordial gravitational wave effects at low ℓ $\rightarrow$ small aperture telescopes
- EE, TE provide new draws of the underlying Gaussian processes $\rightarrow$ **high ℓ is rich!**
- Smaller foregrounds so cleaner $\rightarrow$ **high ℓ is rich!**
- Eventually **lensing** signal will be better than from TT $\rightarrow$ **high ℓ is rich!**

One person's fish is another person's poison.

CMB POLARIZATION: E & B on Celestial Sphere

TEMPERATURE IS A SCALAR

$$\delta T(\theta, \varphi) = \sum_{l,m} a_{lm} Y_{lm}(\theta, \varphi)$$

Nice form!

LINEAR POLARIZATION IS A TENSOR :Requires a magnitude **and** a direction.



Spin-weighted
harmonics

$$(Q + iU)(\hat{n}) = \sum_{\ell,m} a_{\ell m}^{(\pm 2)} [\pm 2 Y_{\ell m}(\hat{n})]$$

E & B: SCALARS
FOR POLARIZATION)

$$a_{\ell m}^E \equiv -\frac{1}{2} \left(a_{\ell m}^{(2)} + a_{\ell m}^{(-2)} \right), \quad a_{\ell m}^B \equiv -\frac{1}{2i} \left(a_{\ell m}^{(2)} - a_{\ell m}^{(-2)} \right)$$

$$E(\hat{n}) = \sum_{\ell,m} a_{\ell m}^E Y_{\ell m}(\hat{n}), \quad B(\hat{n}) = \sum_{\ell,m} a_{\ell m}^B Y_{\ell m}(\hat{n})$$

Nice form!

Seljak & Zaldarriaga 1997; Kamionkowski, Kosowsky, Stebbins 1997 (E→G, B→C)

CMB POLARIZATION: E & B cf Q & U

Full relationships: Seljak & Zaldarriaga 1997 (and Kamionkowski, Kosowsky, Stebbins 1997)

$$(Q + iU)(\hat{n}) = \sum_{\ell, m} a_{\ell m}^{(\pm 2)} [\pm 2 Y_{\ell m}(\hat{n})]$$

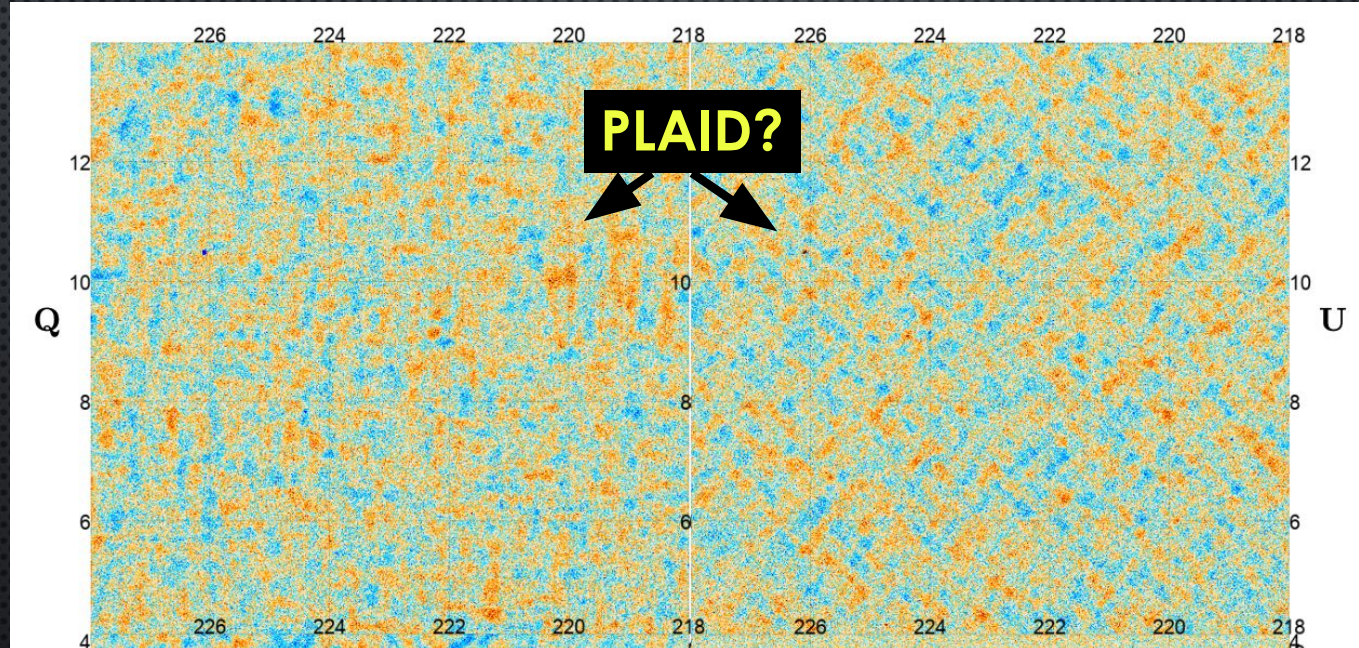
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Flat sky approximations: Zaldarriaga, 2001, PRD 64

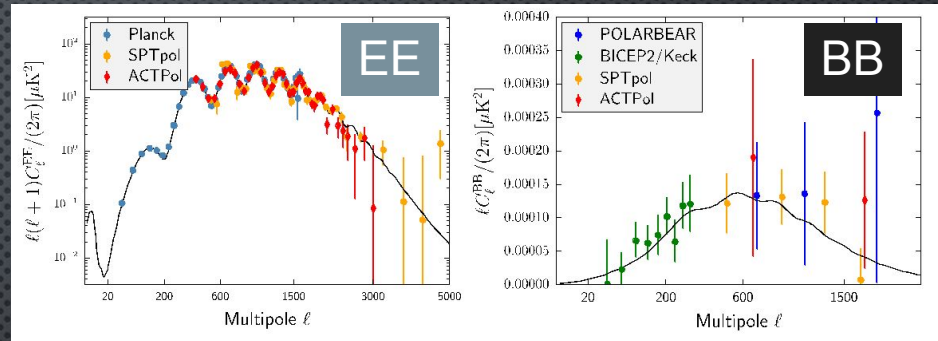
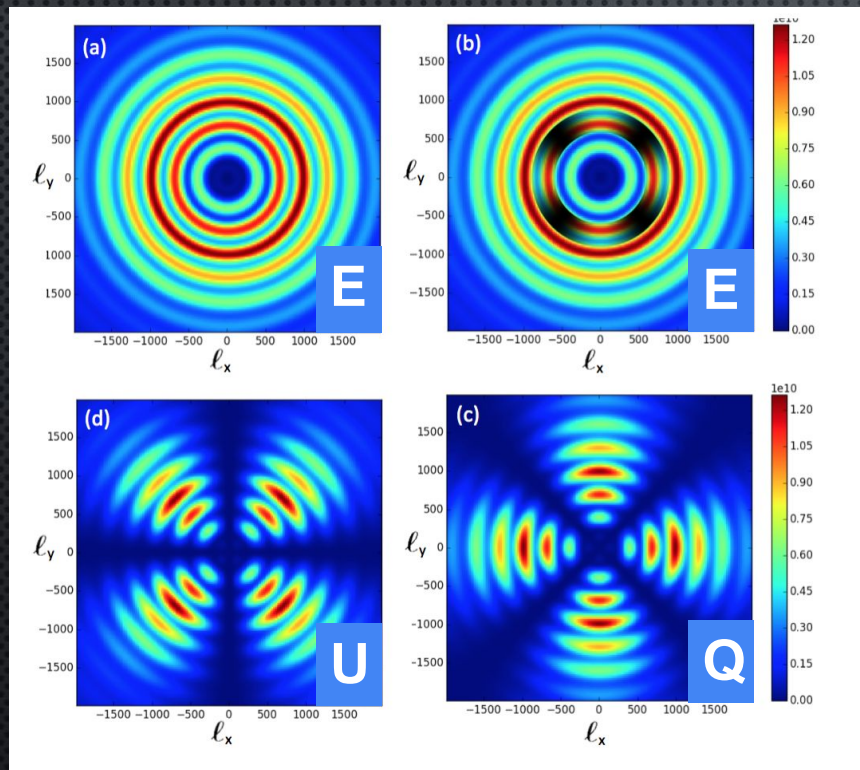
$$Q(\ell) = E(\ell) \cos(2\phi_\ell) - B(\ell) \sin(2\phi_\ell),$$
$$U(\ell) = E(\ell) \sin(2\phi_\ell) + B(\ell) \cos(2\phi_\ell).$$

Example from ACT DR6 (Naess et al 2025)



Characteristic plaid patterns in Q,U indicate E-mode dominance in maps

E-Modes and Plaid Patterns in Q & U



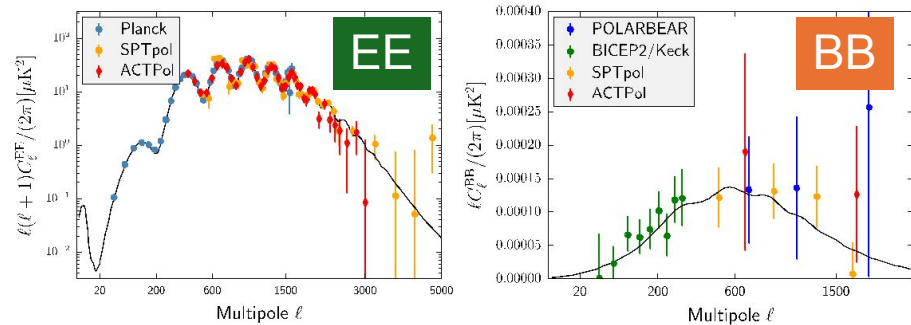
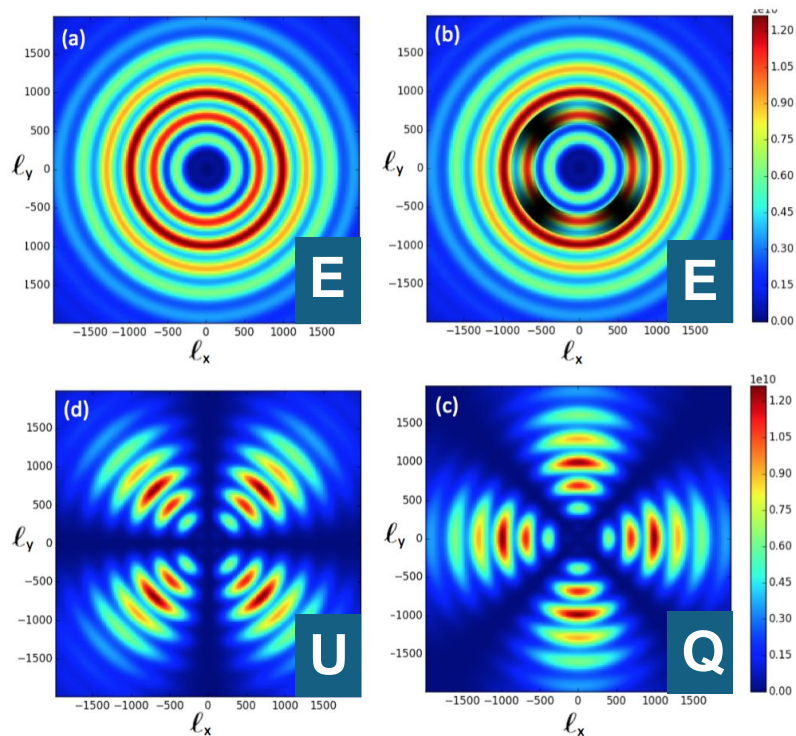
2d Fourier Transform equations pick out horizontal and vertical features in an E-only sky.

Flat sky approximations: Zaldarriaga, 2001, PRD 64

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Simulations courtesy T. Louis (from Staggs, Page, Dunkley, 2017.)



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Simulations courtesy T. Louis (from Staggs, Page, Dunkley, 2017.)

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- 4) **Deeper dive on CMB instruments**

Rationale for New CMB Instruments (including SO)

- 1)The CMB is packed with fundamental information*
- 2)Some of that information is encoded subtly
- 3)We want it all

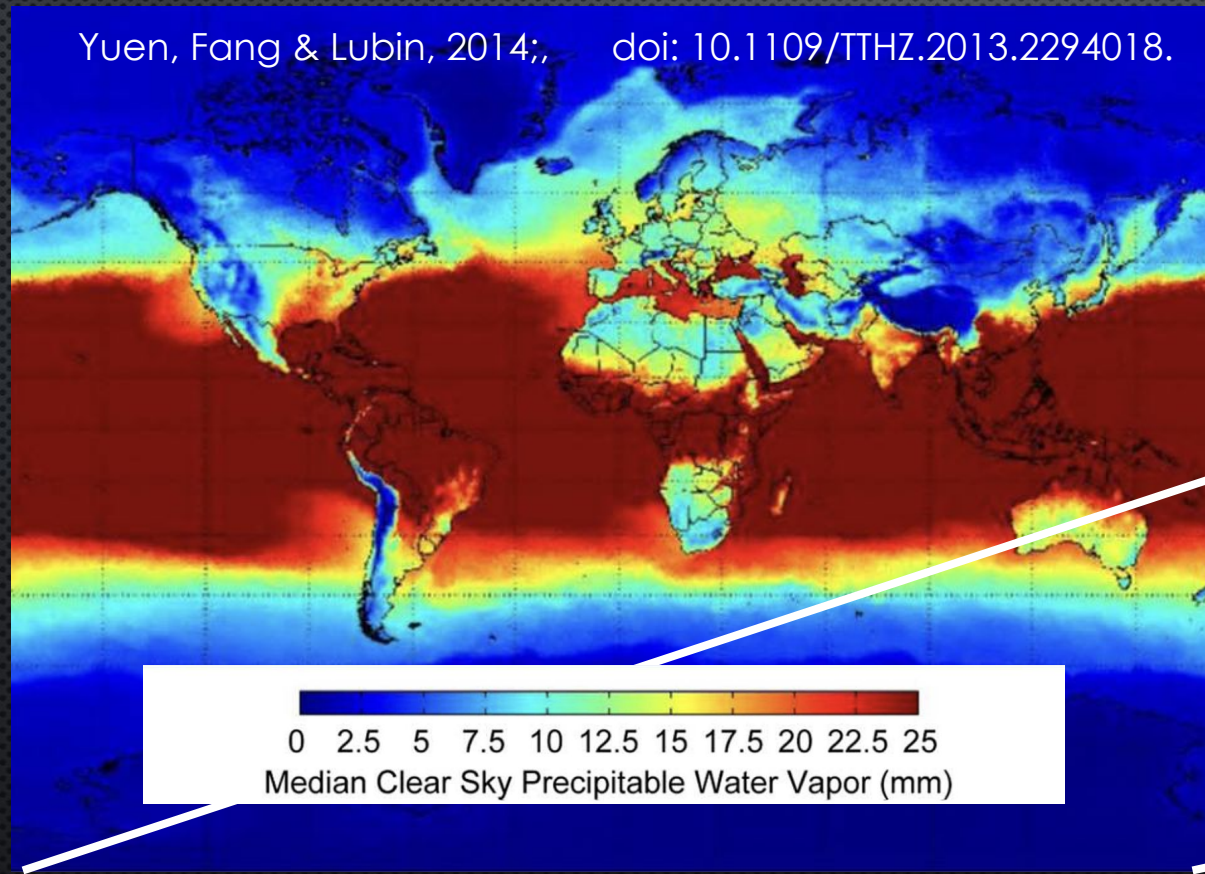


Things driving the design of CMB instruments:

- **platform (ground, balloon, satellite)**
 - these slides focus on ground-based instruments
- **sensitivity**
 - mandates 100 mK detectors & cold optics – and lots of them
 - modulation is needed (fast scanning, polarization modulators)
- **calibration**
 - some calibration is built in; some requires external systems
- **science driver**
 - primordial B-modes: small aperture telescopes are ok
 - high-ell science: large apertures are needed
 - these slides don't address spectral distortion instruments

ATMOSPHERE. ATMOSPHERE. ATMOSPHERE. ATMOSPHERE.

Yuen, Fang & Lubin, 2014; doi: 10.1109/THZ.2013.2294018.

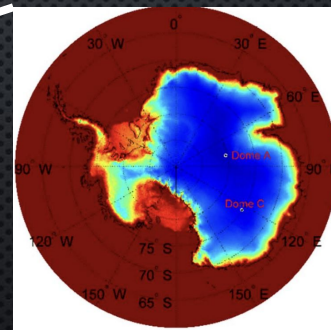


It gets in the way.

(Thus the appeal of balloons & satellites!)

Go dry or go home!

Except for $f < 20$ GHz



Atacama
Desert

Antarctica

Tibetan
Plateau

Greenland

DRY SITES & CURRENT(ISH) INSTRUMENTATION

SIMONS OBSERVATORY
LAT (6m) & SATs

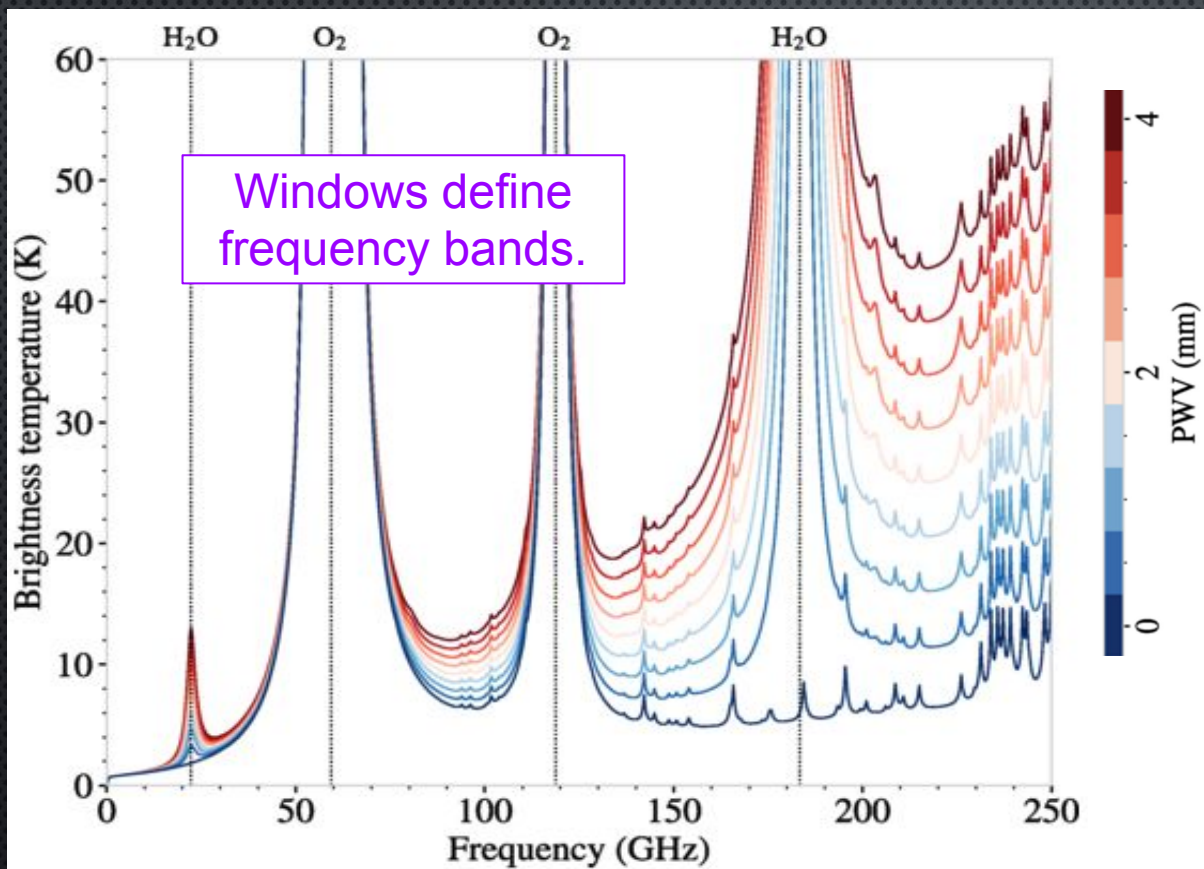
CLASS

SPT, 10m

BICEP Telescopes



ATMOSPHERE. ATMOSPHERE. ATMOSPHERE. ATMOSPHERE.



It gets in the way.

And it adds spurious signal.

Extra signal = extra loading.

The signal varies with elevation,

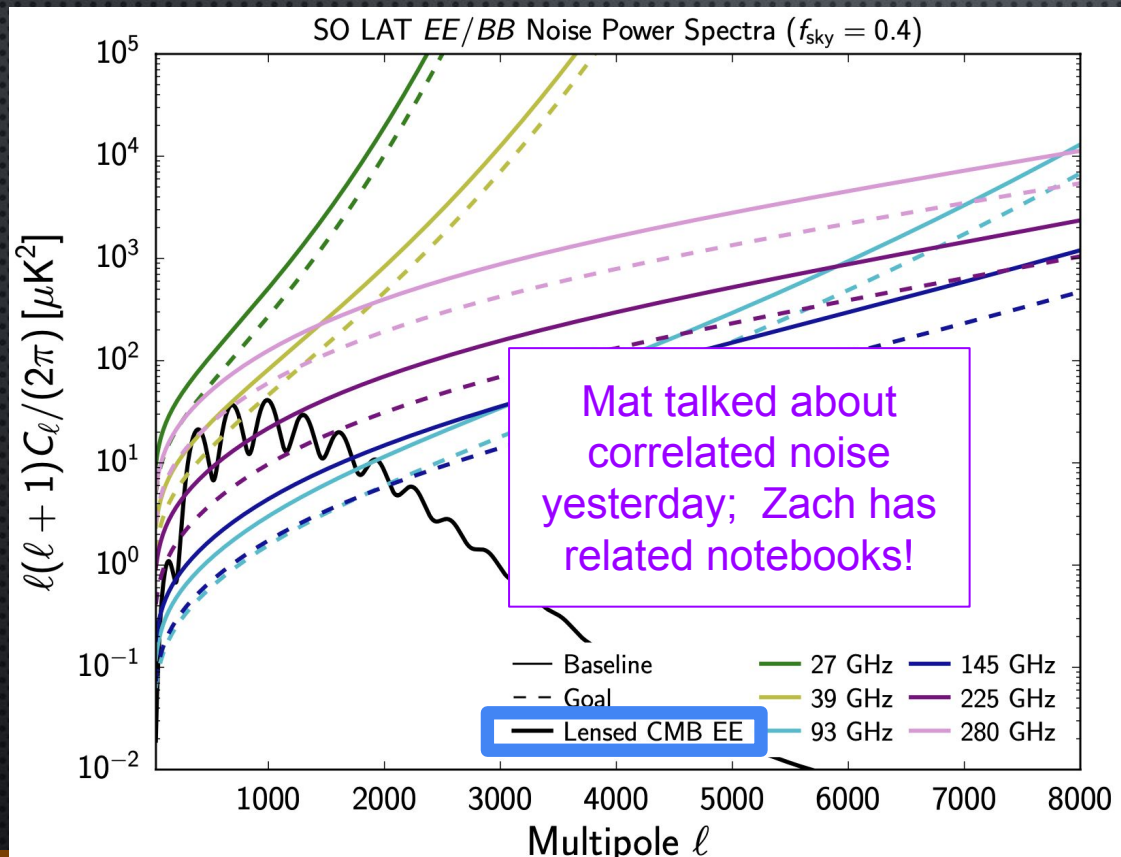
The signal is not constant.

PWV varies with time.

PWV varies with position.

Figure adapted from Morris et al, 2022, PRD 105, 042004; using the am software (S. Paine, 10.5281/zenodo.5794521)

PWV VARIATIONS LEAD TO EXTRA LOW- ℓ NOISE



EXAMPLE: SO LAT (EE/BB)

Focus on solid dark blue 150 GHz curve

Polarization is less impacted by $1/f$ (empirically).

These plots show the SO forecasting noise model, based on ACTpol data.

The beam is apparent at high ℓ and the atmosphere at low ℓ .

From SO Collaboration, 'The Simons Observatory: Science Goals and Forecasts,' 2019 JCAP02(2019)056.

SENSITIVITY FRONTIER

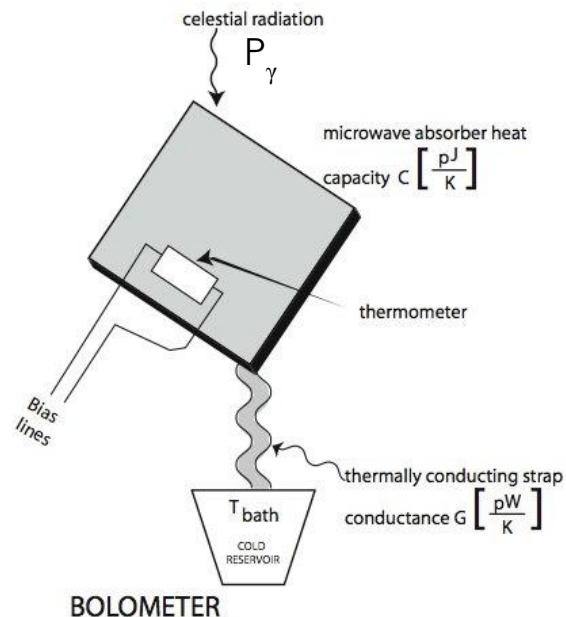
IMPROVING CMB EXPERIMENTS MEANS IMPROVING THE EXPERIMENTAL SENSITIVITY FIRST BY MAKING THE DETECTORS AS SENSITIVE AS POSSIBLE AND THEN BY PUTTING MORE DETECTORS ON THE SKY

GROUND-BASED DETECTORS ARE NOT AS SENSITIVE AS SPACE-BASED ONES DUE TO THE EXTRA SIGNAL FROM THE ATMOSPHERE

SOMETIMES YOU NEED A BUNCH OF TELESCOPES TO HOUSE THEM ALL

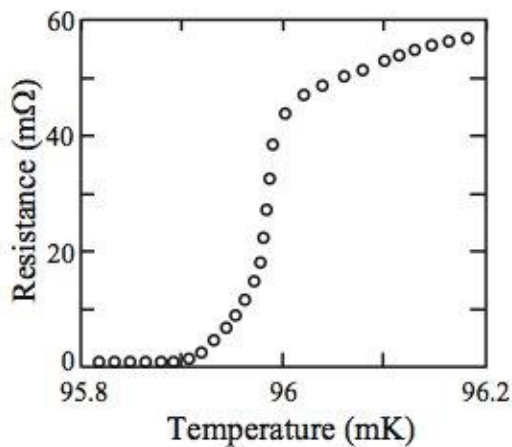
FROM THE GROUND YOU CAN DO THAT. IT IS CHALLENGING.

TES BOLOMETERS



Use superconductor near T_c as thermometer:

Voltage bias $\rightarrow$ electrothermal feedback



Total power warming the bolometer is $P_\gamma + P_J$

+

$P_\gamma \uparrow$ means $T \uparrow$
 $T \uparrow$ **means** $R \uparrow$
 $R \uparrow$ means $P_J \downarrow$

TES Bolometers & Their Multiplexing are Game Changing for Sensitivity

However they bring about some peculiarities;

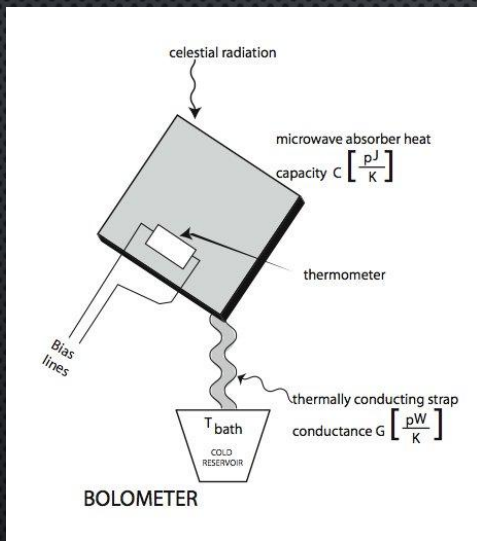
namely, the detectors cease to work if there is too much signal but also cease to work if there is too little signal!

moreover the multiplexed readout uses SQUIDs to measure the tiny current fluctuations; SQUIDs respond quite nonlinearly.

Finally, with 10s of 1000s of detectors, you only understand the “typical behavior” most of the time and rely on cuts to get rid of atypical detectors.

DETECTOR SENSITIVITIES: BOLOMETERS

NEP (units $\text{W Hz}^{-1/2}$) and NET (units $\text{mK s}^{1/2}$)



$$\text{NEP}_{\text{Dicke}} = \sqrt{\frac{p_{\gamma}^2}{b \Delta\nu}}$$

$$\text{NEP}_{\text{shot}} = \sqrt{\frac{h\nu p_{\gamma}}{b}}$$

$$\text{NEP}_G = \sqrt{4kT_0^2 G f_{\ell}}$$

p_{γ} : the incident photon power

b : conversion factor (0.5) to get units $\text{Hz}^{-1/2}$

$\Delta\nu$: bandwidth

ν : center frequency

f_{ℓ} : context dependent factor ≤ 1

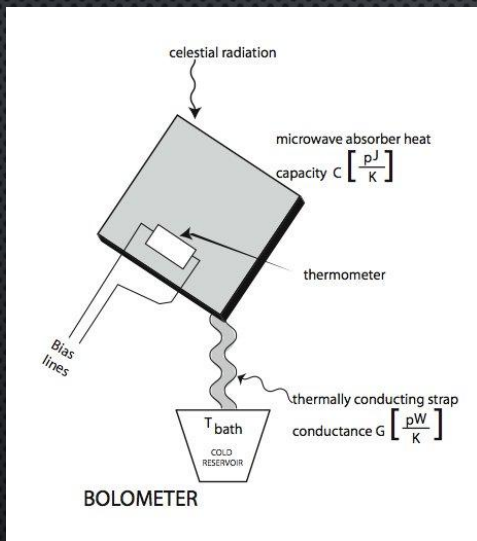
Add these (++) in quadrature to get the total.

Note the NEP_G enters when the input power is transduced into a thermal signature for some kind of thermometer.

Mather, 1982 (Applied Optics)
Zmuidzinas, 2003 (Applied Optics)

DETECTOR SENSITIVITIES: BOLOMETERS

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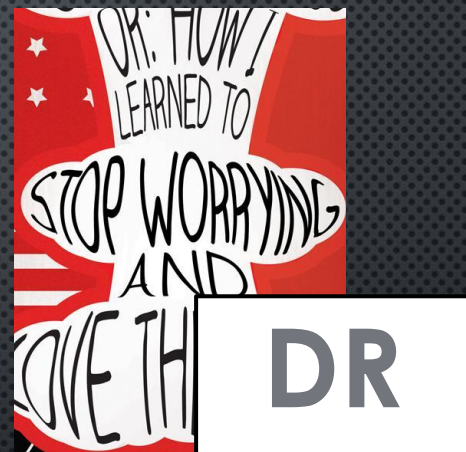
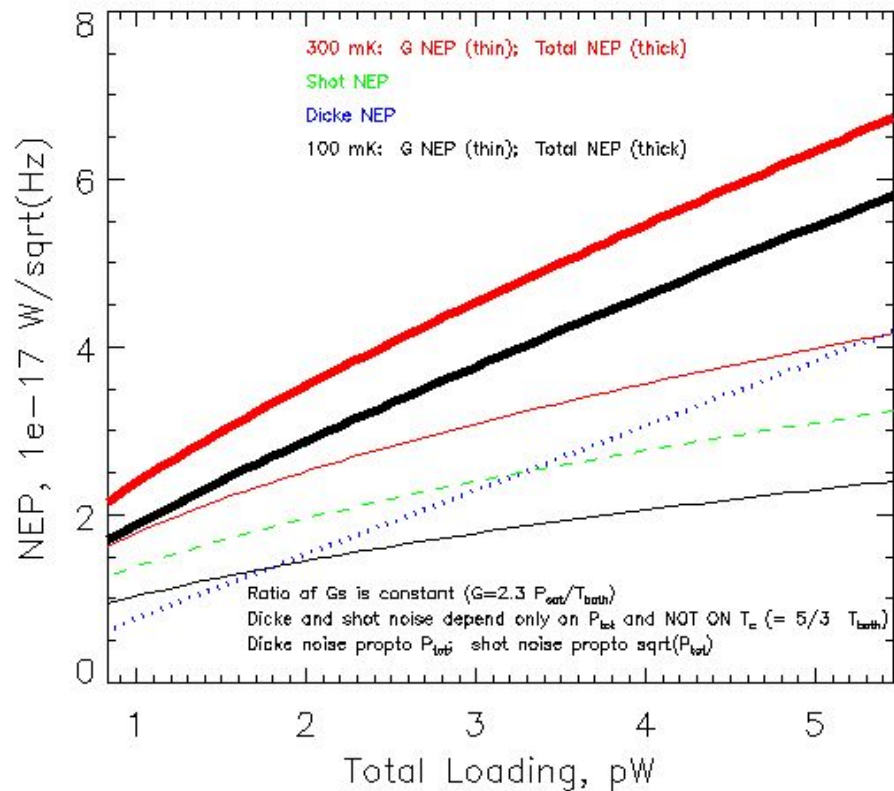
ν : center frequency

f_{ℓ} : context dependent factor ≤ 1

$\text{NEP}_{\text{Dicke}}$ and NEP_{shot} both get worse when p_{γ} increases.
 Atmosphere increases p_{γ}
 NEP_G also gets worse, since G increases so $G(T_0 - T_{\text{bath}}) > p_{\gamma}$

Only one thing helps!

DETECTOR SENSITIVITIES: 100 mK & “BACKGROUND LIMITED”



MODERN PULSE-TUBE BACKED DILUTION FRIDGES
ARE EASIER TO USE THAN ^3He SYSTEMS
(more cooling power – 100-300 μW typical at 100 mK)

We've been running one at 17kft in Chile since 2012.

CHALLENGE OF ATMOSPHERE: SENSITIVITY REQUIRES LOTS OF 100 mK DETECTORS

SO, BICEP Array, CMB-S4, Ali-CPT & others:
detector modules based on 150 mm detector wafers

Then, 100,000 detectors ~ 50-100 modules.

Also requires
highly
multiplexed
readout!

Each module has:

- 1 detector wafer
- 4 optical coupling wafers, aligned & glued
- 1 multi-layer interface ("routing") wafer
- 28 multiplexing chips
- 1 feedhorn array
- 1 high-precision mounting tray

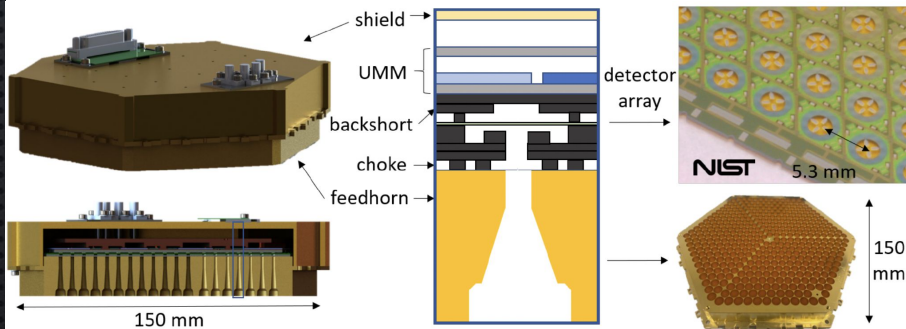
- 1 lid
- 1 magnetic shield
- 2 PCBs, one with imbedded flex & MDM
- 4 coax connections
- Pogo pins, tripod springs, washers, screws

Each module requires:

- Precision gluing of parts (CTE alignments)
- ~ 12,000 aluminum wire bonds
- ~ 100 gold wire bobs
- Pre-assembly screening of most parts
- Two stages of testing at 100 mK

PAROCHIAL EXAMPLE of SO:

60 modules (compared to 3 modules for ACT DR6)



McCarrick, Healy et al, 2021, for JLTP, arXiv:2112.01458

MORE DETECTORS → HUGE RECEIVERS + HIGH THROUGHPUT PRODUCTION OF OPTICS



SO LAT Receiver
2.4 m dia

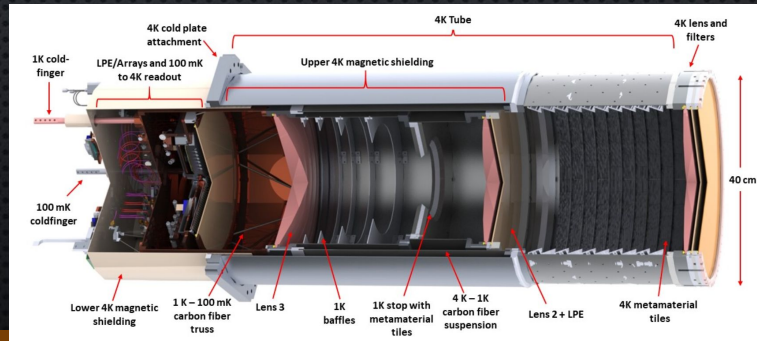
Xu et al, 2020; SPIE 11453,
doi:10.1117/12.2576151.

SO LAT holds 13 optics tubes (36-cm) & SO SATs are 6 optics tubes

Each LAT tube has: 3 AR-coated silicon lenses, 1 AR-coated window, 1 AR-coated alumina filter, and free-space filters

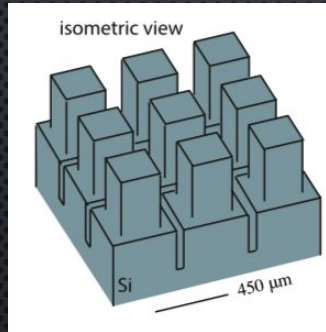
Each SO SAT (42 cm stop) has the same elements + an extra AR-coated alumina filter and an AR-coated sapphire HWP

BICEP ARRAY & SPT-3G+ & CCAT also need many AR-coated optical elements!



It could be worse if
not for DRs!

PRODUCTION CHALLENGE: HIGH TRANSMISSION OPTICAL SYSTEMS

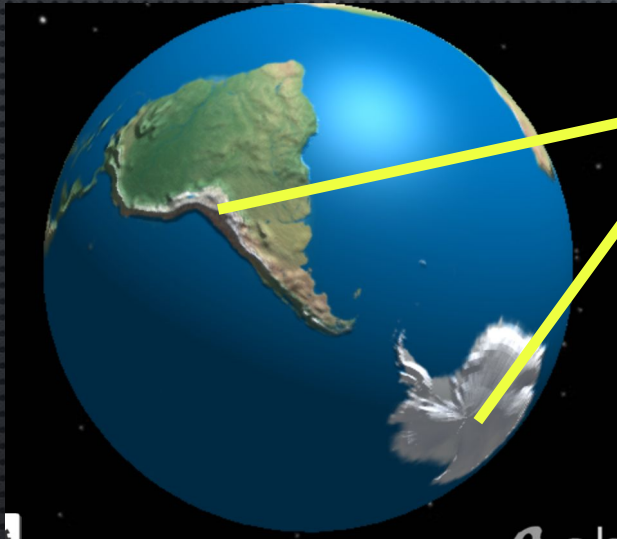


Datta et al 2013



ACT, SO, CCAT+: Silicon
lenses ($n=3.4$) with
metamaterial AR coating

CHALLENGE OF ATMOSPHERE → SPECIFIC SITES



Great for observations but remote and with **complicated stakeholder situations**

- Remote → off the grid
 - Power is not cheap
 - Expanding power supply requires civil construction not just \$\$ to the electric company
 - Access for personnel
 - South Pole – (only a) small on-site team has good year-round access to instrument
 - Chile – easy year-round access for entire team, but the instrument site itself is not always accessible
- Distributed workforce
- Safety, communications, hiring, shipping

The 'complicated stakeholder situations' at the South Pole have become severe, preventing near-term access for CMB-S4.

ACCESS

One possible advantage of ground-based instruments may be the ability to use artificial polarized sources to calibrate polarization angles

Another advantage (though necessary) is there are no weight limitations for shielding the telescope.

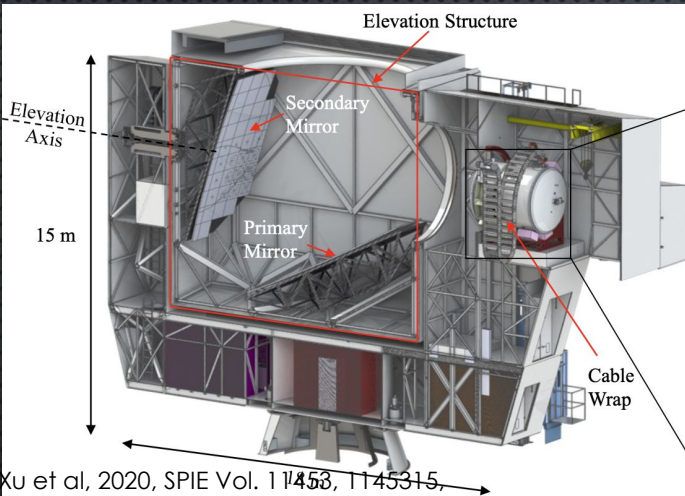
The 6m ACT has a co-moving shield as well as an 1.1 m fixed shield.

Phased rollout of instrumentation allows modifications to optimize outcomes

Photo credit: Rolando Dünner

Atacama Cosmology
Telescope (ACT)

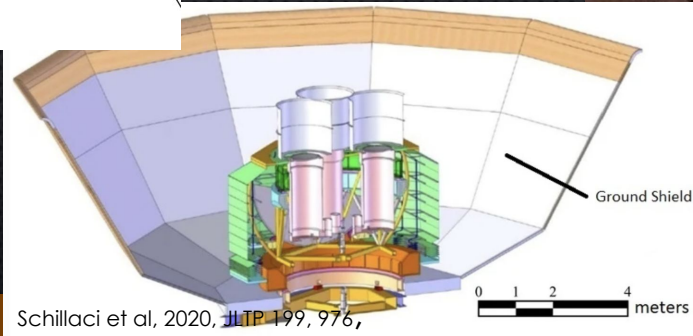
EXAMPLES OF DEFENDING AGAINST GROUND PICKUP FOR GROUND-BASED EXPERIMENTS



BICEP ARRAY in its large ground screen

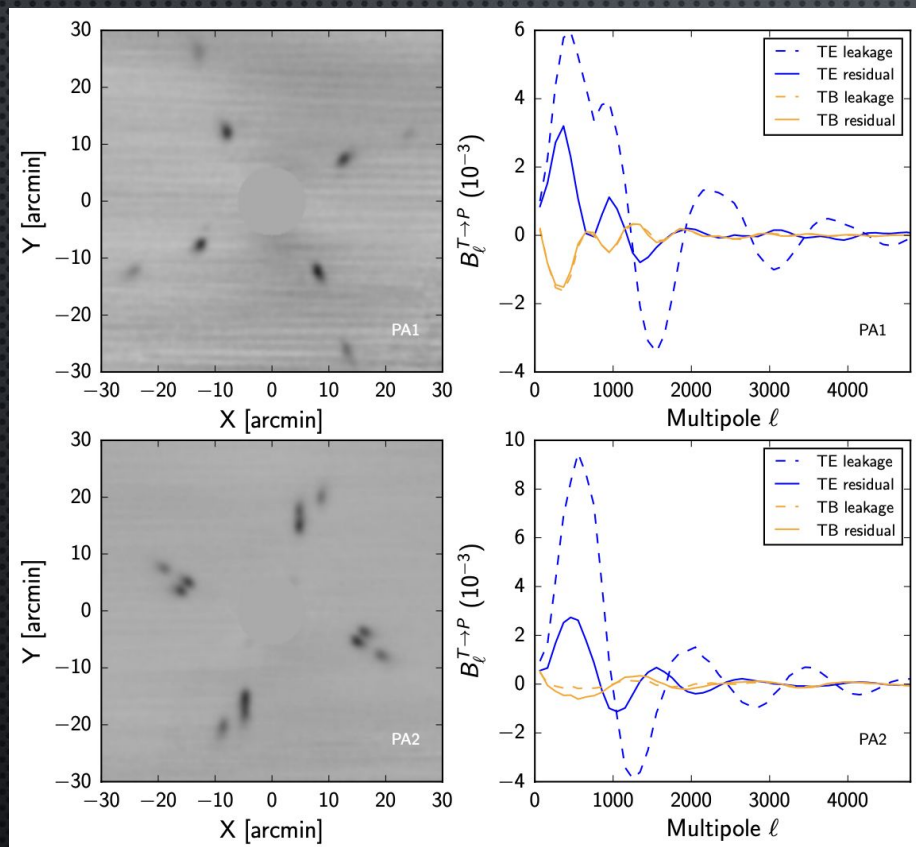


SO Small Aperture Telescopes inside their large ground screens



SO Large Aperture Telescope (LAT); same design for CCAT & CMB-S4

MULTIPLE OPTICAL ELEMENTS IN CRYOGENIC OPTICS TUBES CAN LEAD TO SURPRISES



Polarized sidelobe structure
in the ACTPol receiver

Fall down seven
times, get up eight.

JUST DO IT.

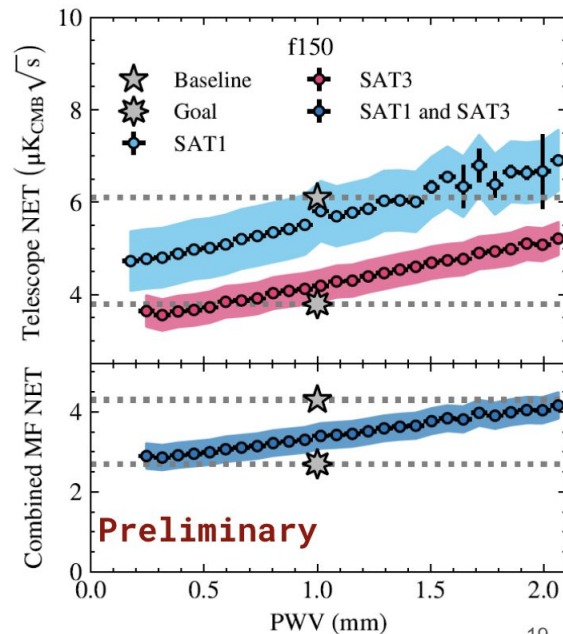
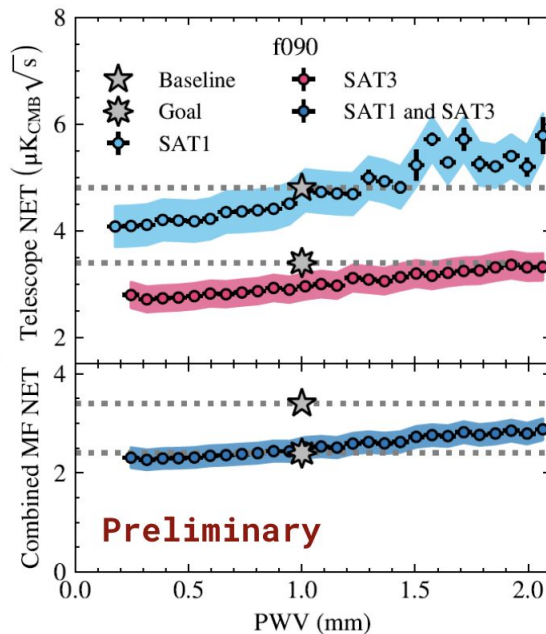
PROGRESS DESPITE CHALLENGES!

Example from
a talk last
week at SPIE
by Katie
Harrington
showing the
SO SAT
performance
exceeds
requirements.

Telescope NETs

All telescopes
performing better
than baseline!
Commissioning
goal achieved!

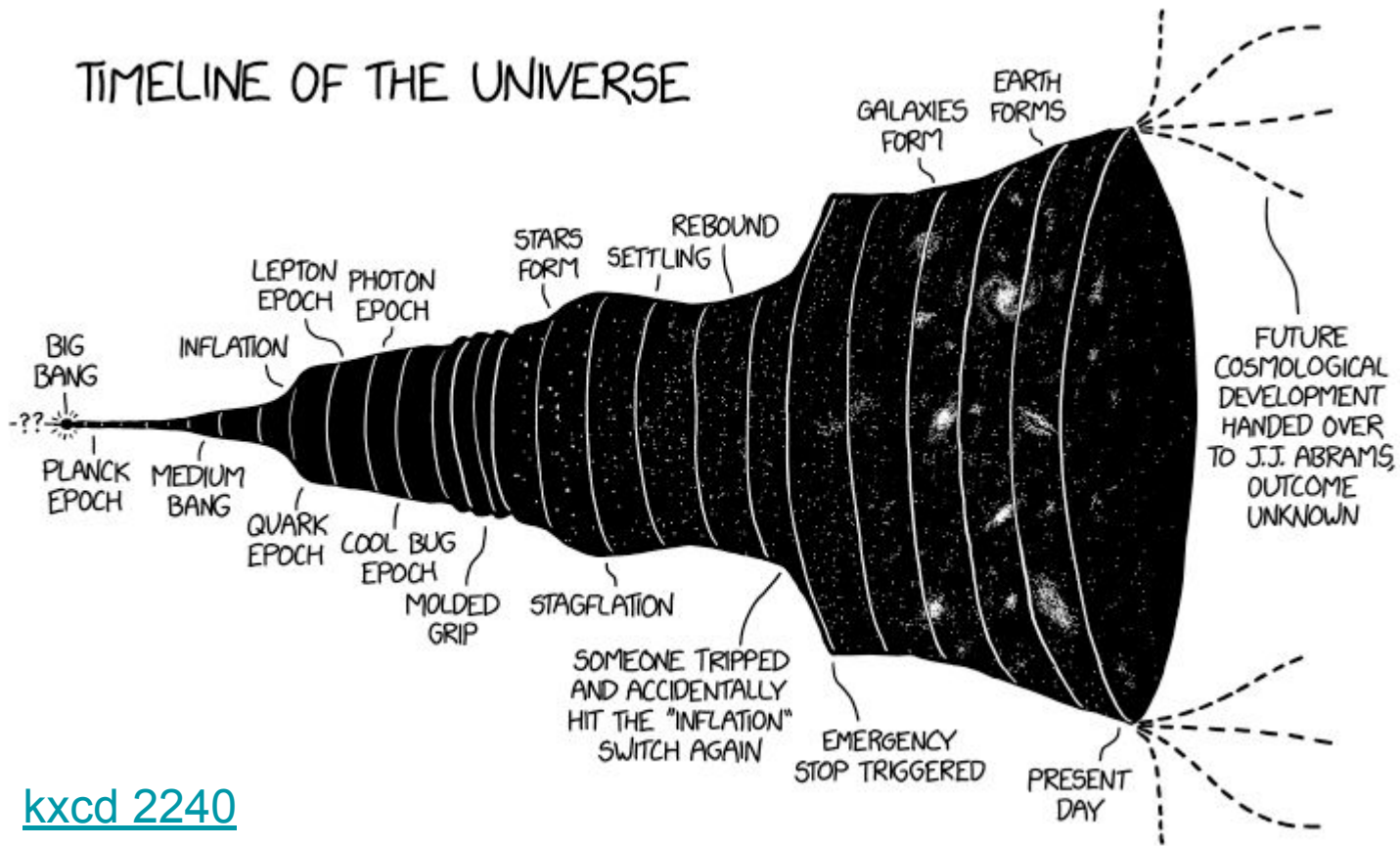
Combined 90 GHz
sensitivity is near
goal.





END SLIDE

TIMELINE OF THE UNIVERSE



[kxcd 2240](#)